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NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN OF THE
25th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
OF
NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

TO BE HELD ON THURSDAY 26 NOVEMBER 2009
AT 8 CHAUCER STREET HAMILTON
AT 11.00am

1. OPENING & WELCOME
BY CHAIRMAN, MR HENRY CHAN OAM
2. APOLOGIES
3. MINUTES OF 2008 AGM
4. BUSINESS ARISING
5. PRESENTATION OF REPORTS
6. CONFIRMATION OF AUDITORS
7. ELECTION -NSS BOARD OF MANAGEMENT(2010)
8. GENERAL BUSINESS
9. CLOSE & LIGHT REFRESHMENTS

GUEST SPEAKER: Mr Jon Chin
Chief Executive Officer
Hexham Bowling Club

Board of Management

As at 30 June 2009

Henry Chan OAM	Chairman
William Simanowsky	Deputy Chairman
Trudy Mills-Evers AM	Treasurer, Public Officer, Finance & Audit Committee
Biko Syongoh	Director, Assistant Treasurer Finance & Audit Committee
Sania Young	Secretary, Finance & Audit Committee
Christine Jordan	Assistant Secretary
Fr Nicholas Zervas OAM	Director, Australia Day Committee, OAM
Zoran Vasiljevic	Director
Ibrahim Nduwamungu	Director
Anna Marendy	Director <i>appointed 27.11.2008</i>)
Resignations:	<i>Ms Alina Kizeweter, Mr Ivan Klopčic OAM</i>



Alina Kizeweter

Seventeen years of service on the Board of Northern Settlement Services

Alina Kizeweter has been a member of the NSS Board since 1991 and Company Secretary since 1994. Ms Kizeweter has been President of the Polish Association of Newcastle for the last 8 years and is actively involved in the Association's welfare group.

Her community involvement has also included Membership of the Board of the Maximilian Kolbe Wing of the St Joseph's Aged Care at Beresfield NSW.

Ms Kizeweter volunteers in the Community Visitors Scheme and also at the Polish Day Care Centre.

Ms Kizeweter has played a crucial role in maintaining a strong and cohesive Polish community in the Hunter. She has been especially active in cultural promotion in the city and instrumental in raising awareness in the Hunter of the contribution by early settlers and visitors of Polish descent - a contribution now incorporated in landmarks around our city, and in exhibits in regional libraries and museums.

At the 2008 Annual General Meeting, Ms Kizeweter resigned from the NSS Board after seventeen years of service.

NSS Management and Staff acknowledged her time and dedication to the community and her role on the Board and wished her good health and happiness in the future.

Alina responded with these words...



Resignation Speech by Alina Kizeweter

2008 Annual General Meeting

Dear Friends,

It is with mixed feelings that I now offer my resignation from the Board of Northern Settlement Services Limited. I am proud to say that I have been a member of the Management Committee since 1991 and that I have had the privilege of serving as a Secretary since 1994. I am sad to no longer be a part of this Organisation which offers so much to the community, but I am happy and satisfied with all that we have achieved.

During my time in the organisation I have witnessed the great work of many selfless people who have contributed much to the new members of our community. So many newcomers have benefited from the multilingual information and referral, casework and counselling, community education and development our staff under the directorship of Violetta Walsh has provided.

I am thankful that our staff has been able to offer settlement services to refugees and migrants of non-English speaking background. Our entire team should be proud of how we have promoted access and equity in service delivery to our refugees and migrants and supported the activities and projects of multicultural and diverse interest groups in the community.

I offer my sincerest thanks to all my co-workers and praise them for their diligent efforts. Special thanks also go to our Chairman Henry Chan, who has served on the Migrant Resource Management Committee since 1988.

Chairman Chan is very adept at overseeing our team and efforts. I have learned much from him.

I wish the NSS continued success and growth. I will follow your progress with pride and look forward to hearing from you all again.



Ivan Klopčič OAM

19 August 1919 - 28 November 2008

Twelve years of service on the Board of Northern Settlement Services

Mr Ivan John Klopčič was a member of the NSS Board since 1996.

He was the President of the Slovenian Association for 38 years and prior to his early retirement, he was the delegate of the FIA (Federated Ironworkers Association) for 28 years, gaining extensive experience in industrial matters.

He continued to represent the workforce of NESB as part of the FIA's Ethnic Access Committee. Mr Klopčič was a member of the Hunter Region Advisory Committee to the NSW Ethnic Affairs Commission for 2 years.

Mr Klopčič was an active volunteer with Community Visitors Scheme (a program supporting aged Nursing Home residents of NESB) and he worked as a Volunteer trainer in support programs for brain injured people.

Mr Klopčič had particular experience with aged people of NESB, and had great knowledge of long settled refugee communities in the Hunter.

In 2002, Mr Klopčič received a Medal of the Order of Australia, for service to the Slovenian Community of the Hunter region, particularly in the area of aged care.

*Mr Klopčič was a valued friend & colleague to the NSS Board & Staff.
He will be remembered in the hearts of many.*

Staff

As at 30 June 2009

Chief Executive Officer	Ms Violetta Walsh OAM
Special Project Team Leader	
Assistant CEO/Migration Agent	Ms Lulu Tantos
Migration Agent	Ms Irina Lupish/ Mr Richard Hardy
Financial Controller	Ms Arlene Richards
Assistant Financial Controller	Ms Marianne Mohr
Office Manager	Ms Mary Milevski
Information & Referral: Senior Administration Officer	Ms Silvia Ruano
Information & Referral: Administration Officer	Ms Helen Short
Information & Referral: Administration Trainee	Ms Jacinta Boidin
Information & Referral: Administration On-call Staff	Ms Lydia Manusiu (til 1/10), Ms Olivia Graham, and Ms Wendy Kirkham
OH&S Consultant	Ms Helen Buchanan
Rural Projects Team Leader	Mr Alex Burns
Hunter Welfare Outreach SGP	Ms Rose Oku
New England SGP Worker (Tamworth)	Ms Amalin Sundaravej
New England SGP Worker (Armidale)	Ms Judith Roberts
New England SGP Worker (Inverell)	Ms Katie Wright
Aged Services Team Leader	Ms Slavica (Sue) Hristov
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator	
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator 2	Ms Lupe Fonua
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator 3	Ms Tima 'Oto
Tax Help Officer	
Hunter Multicultural Respite Service	Ms Tima 'Oto
CVS Coordinator	Ms Enza Di Stefano
Multicultural Access Project (commenced 10/09)	Ms Valerie Woodman
Central Coast Team Leader / Multicultural Social Support Service Senior Coordinator	Ms Sandra Wingrave
Multicultural Social Support Service Coordinator	Ms Olivia Fuente
Central Coast Office Manager	Ms Trudy Wahl
Central Coast SGP Worker	Ms Danielle Habib
Multicultural Family Worker	Ms Pari Batha
African Team Leader / Complex Case Support Officer	Ms Kiri Hata
African Family Support	Ms Helen Buchanan
Volunteers Coordinator	Mr Michael Freund
Mauritanian Support Worker (till 1/11/09)	Mr Alhousseynou Ly
African Welfare Worker	Ms Flora Aine
African Youth Worker	Mr Mohamed Kamara
African Parenting Assistant	Ms Amer Manyuon
African Family Support Workers	Ms Joselyne Ntahomvukiye / Ms Zenaida Edmunds
Welfare Projects Team Leader / Filipino Welfare Worker	Ms Petrona Kelly
Brighter Futures Project Officer	
Multicultural Family Worker (Families First)	Ms Miza Torlakovic
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Samoan) / Tax Help Officer/EAPA	Ms Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Tongan)	Ms Lydia Manusiu (resigned Oct 2009)
Russian Welfare Worker	Ms Elena Ferguson
Thai Welfare Worker / Strong Women, Stronger Communities Project (Domestic Violence Education & Support) (til 1/11/09)	Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Migrant & Refugee Women's Worker	Ms Zenaida Edmunds

**MINUTES OF THE 24th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
MEMBERS OF NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED
THURSDAY 27 NOVEMBER 2008, AT 11.00AM.**

Minutes: MMilevski (Office Manager)

1.ATTENDANCE: Lists attached

2.APOLOGIES: Lists attached

3. AGM Minutes for 2007 – Accepted

Proposed: TMills- Evers

Seconded: SYoung

4. BUSINESS ARISING:

- The DGR application continues to be prepared. VWalsh thanked all staff for complying with report specifications.
- She said a 'Special General Meeting' will be required in January of 2009, to pass amendments to the constitution, prior to re-submitting the DGR application.

5.PRESENTAION OF STAFF REPORTS

HChan – Chairman of the NSS Board: Report tabled & accepted as read.

VWalsh – Director: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Further developments regarding the Complex Case Service – DIAC has accepted our referral. Also DIAC is allowing more flexibility regarding the eligibility criteria.
- NSS Central Coast – negotiations are continuing regarding the re-auspice of DoCS & DIAC projects
- VWalsh thanked Sandra Wingrave for her assistance & her initiative to promoted the opportunity to house the projects at the existing NSS Central Coast site. This becomes a new NSS service 'hub' for the Central Coast.
- HChan commented on the benefit of the Team structure, especially with regard to the streamlining of the monthly reports presented to the Board.

Special Projects: Reports tabled & accepted as read.

- An assessment of the IMMAD commercial service may be required based on the outcome of the DGR application.
- IMMAD continues to be busy
- Kiri Hata welcomed to NSS & introduced as a new member of the Special Projects Team.

Rural Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read.

- ABurns reported Daisy Brown has officially resigned & Katie Wright has been appointed to the position.

Aged Care Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read.

- SHristov reported that it had been a busy year, with many clients moving to 'higher care'. She said the year had also presented many new challenges to the project & team. She noted that a submission for more funding has been prepared.

Central Coast Team – MSSS: Reports tabled & accepted as read.

- Trudy Wahl was introduced as the new Administration worker
- The project had also relocated to Bateau Bay which offers a more central location & is more appropriate to the service.

African Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read.

- MFreund commented that volunteers continued to support NSS initiatives to assist refugees settle & establish their lives in the local community. He also mentioned the undertaking of a Volunteer audit which serves to ensure the collection of accurate information on volunteers & the establishment of a third Homework centre.
- VWalsh thanked Board member BSyongoh for his commitment to the management & operation of the African community radio program.

Welfare Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read.

- MTorlakovic thanked ABurns for his ongoing support over the years under his guidance, in her (previous) role as an CSS/SGP worker.

STAFF REPORTS – Accepted:

Proposed: IKlopcic

Seconded: Fthr Zervas

Presentation of AUDITED STATEMENTS – MR MARK O’CONNOR, Cutcher & Neale (C&N)

- Mr O’Connor provided a brief summary of the NSS financial report. He offered special recognition of the NSS Finance Team, especially ARichards, for the successful management of the NSS accounts.
- It was noted that the Audit committee continue to meet every 3 months & the meetings minuted. The proposals made by C&N were acknowledged & the Audit committee will consider these during future meetings.
- The Board confirmed that C&N will be the Auditors for the coming year.

FINANCIAL REPORTS – Accepted

Proposed: Fthr Zervas

Seconded: SYoung

Nominations for the 2009 NSS Board include:

Henry Chan
 William Simanowsky
 Trudy Mills-Evers
 Sania Young
 Fthr Nicholas Zervas
 Zoran Vasiljevic
 Ivan Klopac
 Biko Syongoh
 Christine Jordan (*proposed member*)
 Anna Marendy (*proposed member*)
 Ibrahim Nduwamungu (*proposed member*)

GENERAL BUSINESS:

- AKizweter announced her retirement from the NSS Board. HChan acknowledged her decision with respect, noting that she will be missed. AKizweter offered her assistance if ever required.
- A gift of appreciation & a service acknowledgement certificate were presented to AKizweter. VWalsh made mention of Alina's contribution to the Board & her achievements in the community. Alina forwarded her thanks & reply.
- ABurns acknowledged the loss of valued NSS staff member Anne Dupree.
- LTantos reported on her Canberra visit to attend the launch of National Settlement Council. NSS has membership & a chance to be represented by this body.
- NSS (public) member Adam Lepidis offered his congratulations to the NSS staff for the production of a professional AGM report.
- HChan expressed his appreciation to all NSS Staff, volunteers, members & his fellow Board Directors for their attendance & commitment to NSS.

MEETING CLOSED 12.30pm

***Signed by the Chairman at the
 Annual General Meeting held on
 27th November 2008 at NSS premises***

ATTENDANCE & APOLOGIES

24th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Thursday 27 November 2008, 11.00am

	Name	Community/Group/Organisation
1	Fr. Nicholas Zervas OAM	NSS Board / Greek Community of Newcastle
2	Ivan Klopčič OAM	NSS Board/ Slovenian Community of Newcastle
3	Sania Young	NSS Board/ Tartar Community
4	Denise Hodgson	Centrelink
6	Tima Oto	NSS/ Tongan Community
7	Sue Hristov	NSS
9	Juanita Loli	NSS/ Samoan Community
10	Lupe Fonua	NSS
12	Mark O'Connor	Cutcher & Neale
13	Alina Kizeweter	Secretary/ Polish Community
14	Henry Chan OAM	Chairman: NSS Management Committee
15	William Simanowsky	Vice Chairman: NSS Management Committee
16	Elena Ferguson	NSS
17	Zenaida Edmunds	NSS/ MNC
18	Pet Kelly	NSS
19	Enza Distefano	NSS
20	Mary Milevski	NSS
21	Silvia Ruano	NSS
22	Helen Short	NSS
23	Violetta Walsh OAM	NSS
24	Miza Torlakovic	NSS
25	Victor Lupish	Ethnic Choral & Russian Community
26	Biko Syongoh	HACC
27	Marianne Mohr	NSS
28	Trudy Wahl	NSS
29	Lulu Tantos	NSS
30	Arlene Richards	NSS
31	Alex Burns	NSS
32	Rose Oku	NSS
33	Barbara Byng	NSS
34	Irina Lupish	NSS
35	Michael Todd	Macedonian Community
36	Christine Jordan	Polish Association
37	Trudy Mills-Evers AM	NSS Board
38	Angelina Filchakova	TAFE Student (placement)
39	Christina Chatziconstantinos	Centrelink (TAFE Student Placement)
40	Anna Marendy	Hippocrates Association
41	Adam Lepidis	Pavlos-Melas Macedonian Brotherhood
42	Mohamed T Kamara	NSS
43	Nellie Srisurapon	NSS
44	Michael Freund	NSS
45	Gail Maffesoni	DoCS
46	Helen Buchanan	NSS
47	Sandra Wingrave	NSS
48	Kiri Hata	NSS
APOLOGY	Michael Addereley	Housing
APOLOGY	Zoran Vasiljevic	NSS Board
APOLOGY	Ibrahim Nduwamungu	Centrelink
APOLOGY	Sinead Buckley	Member
APOLOGY	Olivia Fuente	NSS



Overview of 2009 Northern Settlement Services Limited

Funding Partnerships

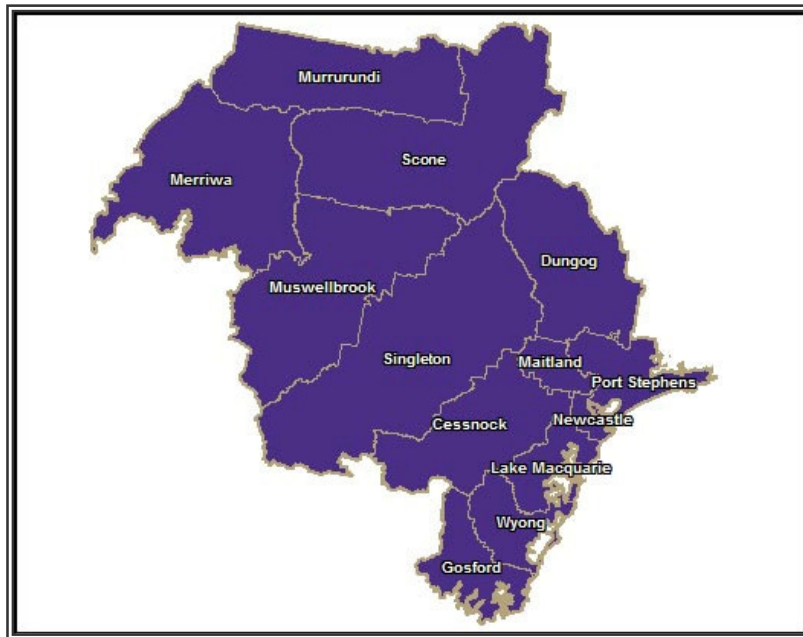
Department of Immigration & Citizenship (DIAC)
 NSW Department of Community Services (DoCS)
 Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing
 NSW Department of Ageing Disability & Home Care (DADHC)
 Community Development Support Expenditure (Registered Clubs NSW)
 Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs (FaHCSIA)

Clients by Ethnic Background

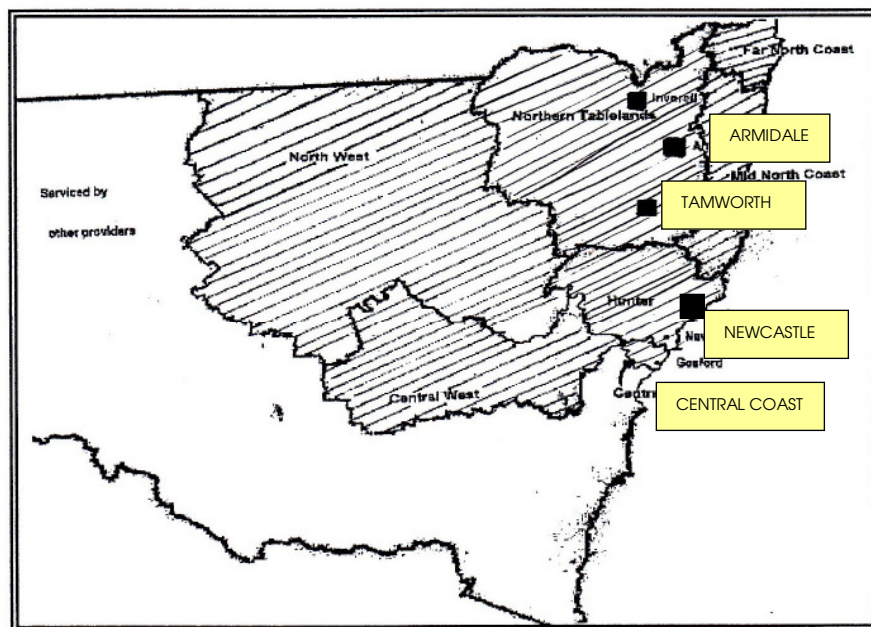
Afghanistan	Fiji	Liberia	Senegal
Albania	Finland	Malaysia	Serbia
Algeria	France	Mauritania	Slovenia
Argentina	Germany	Montenegro	Sierra Leone
Australia	Greece	Macedonia	Singapore
Austria	Guatemala	Mexico	Somalia
Bangladesh	Honduras	Morocco	South Africa
Bosnia	Hungary	Nepal	Sri Lanka
Botswana	Hong Kong	Netherlands	Spain
Brazil	India	New Zealand	Sudan
Burundi	Indonesia	Nigeria	Sweden
Canada	Ireland	Norway	Switzerland
Chile	Iran	Panama	Syria
China	Iraq	Pakistan	Tahiti
Colombia	Italy	Papua New Guinea	Taiwan
Congo (DRC)	Japan	Paraguay	Thailand
Croatia	Jordan	Peru	Tonga
Cyprus	Kazakhstan	Poland	Turkey
Czech Republic	Kenya	Portugal	Ukraine
Dominican Republic	Korea	Philippines	Uruguay
East Timor	Kuwait	Romania	USA
Egypt	Lebanon	Russia	Vietnam
El Salvador	Latvia	Rwanda	Venezuela
England	Lithuania	Scotland	Zimbabwe

OUR SERVICE REGIONS & OFFICE LOCATIONS

HUNTER OUTREACH



OFFICE LOCATIONS & SERVICE REGIONS



Areas serviced by NSS offices & Outreach workers



Chairman's Report

Henry Chan OAM

I am delighted to report that Northern Settlement Services Ltd has completed a particularly outstanding year in its prime mover role of service delivery to migrants and refugees settling in the large geographic area in which we operate.

Our "champagne moment" this year came when we learnt that our organisation was granted the status of a Public Benevolent Institution with endorsement as a Deductible Gift Recipient, with our application backdated to the 1st of January 2007. Clearly the ATO assessed the work we do as being consistent with the broad goals of benevolence, i.e. assisting the most vulnerable and disadvantaged of our client groups and providing services which alleviate hardship, homelessness, helplessness and diminished life opportunities.

I would like to extend the appreciation of everyone concerned to our Honorary Legal Adviser without whose hard work our application would not have been successful.

The achievement of this status is extremely important for us on a number of counts. We are now able to receive donations which are tax deductible to the donors. We are exempt from having to pay Fringe Benefit Tax. We can access other sources of project funding which are only available to Public Benevolent Institutions, and last but not least we can offer our staff salary packaging.

Indeed it is especially pleasing to be able to provide additional benefits to our hard working staff, present and future, in an industry not renowned for high remuneration. Alas, the love of the job is not enough to pay the bills!

On other matters, I had the great pleasure in the course of the year to officiate at the opening of our Central Coast Office which now houses not only our expanding Multicultural Social Support Service, but two new acquisitions, a DIAC funded settlement project and a DOCS Family Welfare both of which are meeting a range of needs in a large and difficult geographic area. Our aged services in Hamilton have also had a significant boost with the addition of the Multicultural Access Project funded by Department of Ageing, Disability and Home Care, and we believe this project will be a catalyst for further service development for our aged. And the renewal of substantial funding by the Department of Immigration and Citizenship for our traditional settlement work both here and in New England, sets us up to "power on" into 2010 and beyond.

As always, I would like to thank the dedicated and hard working team around me, my fellow Board members, our wonderful volunteers, all 200 plus of them, and of course our peerless staff, who keep this great service humming along.



Chief Executive Officer's Report

Violetta Walsh OAM

This is quite a milestone year for me, being a special anniversary. On the 9th April 1984 I was appointed as the Coordinator of the then Migrant Resource Centre of Newcastle and the Hunter Region –a position I have now occupied for 25 years. These days the title has changed, but I am not sure if being around for 25 years is a badge of pride or a cause for embarrassment. Such a length of time in the one job can signify laziness, mediocrity, lack of imagination, at best a lack of opportunity. From another, kinder, point of view, it is a testament to survival in an industry not generally known for its stability, let alone longevity. But here I am still standing- 25 years older, wiser and frankly busier than ever before.

As alluded to by our Chairman, it has been a very productive year, marked by both consolidation and growth in the three sites from which our service operates-here in Newcastle and the Hunter, on the Central Coast and in the New England area. It is a significant geography which validates that name change that we undertook a couple of years ago to better describe our operational reach far beyond the original –the Hunter Region. Our new status as Benevolent Institution validates it even more!

The people we serve remain a combination of migrants from a non English speaking background and refugees, newly arrived and longer settled, all of whom are experiencing difficulty and hardship in their settlement in a new country, struggling with the challenges of adapting to a new language and a new culture, in crises that impact on normal functioning, vulnerable by virtue of their age, their capacity, and circumstances. It is an amazingly diverse group, with about 95 different backgrounds represented in our service records, far outstripping our agency's fairly formidable linguistic capacity among staff -of 25 languages. Our services have strategically targeted the needs of these client groups in their various and far flung geographic areas of settlement and we are appreciative of the ongoing confidence shown to us by our various funding bodies, and our other partners in service delivery, especially in the community sector.

DIAC for example has continued its funding for those core services which still are fundamental to our operation-the provision of information, casework and referral, and community development. And this funding is solid value for money – with our reception area recording close to 30,000 contacts in the course of the year, by phone, via email and in person. Now that's what anyone would call busy!

Other DIAC funding granted allows us to continue to provide specific welfare services to refugees, both adults and young people, in our local area, and continues the settlement work in Tamworth, Armidale and Inverell. Some new funding is especially welcome. It is aimed at supporting the Refugee Homework Centres that our agency has been conducting for several years in selected schools. These have been largely funded to date by the generosity of the Registered Clubs, Life without Barriers and our own resources, but the additional DIAC funds offer an enhancement of the service and more secure coordination.

Our refugee work is a very important part of what we do - with good reason. The settlement needs of this group are very high indeed. They are still predominantly from various countries of Africa, although this is likely to change as Australia focuses its attention to other refugee areas-South East Asia, and the Middle East. Apart from the trauma most have experienced prior to arrival, they must now adapt to our vastly different western urban lifestyle a new language and a very unfamiliar social and cultural environment.

The Complex Case Support work delivered by this agency (courtesy of a successful tender to DIAC) attests to the difficulties people encounter even after several years of settlement. But the real challenge for all of us involved in the settlement effort is to ensure that our compassion is balanced by the encouragement of independence and self sufficiency within the current group of African communities themselves. This is a difficult process, habits of dependence are hard to break, and real leadership is slow to emerge, but it is critical to their long-term successful integration into our way of life.

But there are also other external issues which do impact on their settlement. In this context it is saddening at this time to see controversy return to the subject matter of refugees- who the boat people-whatever description they are being given- overwhelmingly are. It is unedifying to see fear mongering back on the political agenda, on both sides of the divide, and specifically the fear of being swamped. An interesting statistic- Australia has gladly taken over 3 million migrants since World War 2. In that time 30,000 refugees have arrived in an "unauthorised" fashion. Where in that is the danger of being swamped?

This dark cloud aside, our general mood is buoyant. We have been able to maintain the delivery of the suite of services that support the needs of our client groups, and that is due to the fact that our funding has not only continued to be stable but has been enhanced. It is worth noting that this sort of success owes a great deal to our agency's governance and management. Our organisation is strong and stable, thanks to our wonderful Board, very focussed and energetic, thanks to our great staff, and in excellent financial shape, thanks to our marvellous financial managers. The team structure has proved to be a very effective system, and provides a sound supervision and support to the workers involved in their respective compatible programs work. I am sure our readers will be impressed by the range of services that emerge from our comparatively small operation. We do punch above our weight.

As in every year of our operation, we also deal with change. Painfully, useful projects end, and the people in them must move on. One such project was the pilot Citizenship Support Program which effectively assisted intending citizens to prepare for the test - which has now been simplified, and presumably will be easier to prepare for and pass. We have been able to "recycle" a couple of such staff however: Nellie has completed the Domestic Violence Program but continues in Thai Welfare and as a member of the Complex Case Support Team, and Zeni who, with the Women's SGP Project finishing, continues her work in the African Parenting team.

And of course, people retire! A particular loss to retirement is our beloved Irina Lupish, who, for 21 years, played a vital role in this agency and in the last few years as one of our migration agents. She called it a day on 1st November, and how we will miss her skills, her dedication and her wonderful company.

But perhaps one of our most poignant moments came with the death of our dear Ivan Klopčič, just a day after our last AGM. He had served on our Board with such dedication for close to 20 years, a true champion of the community, a shining example of community leadership.

New faces have appeared in the agency as well - Flora Aine in Refugee Welfare, Val Woodman on board as our DADHC funded Multicultural Access Worker, Jacinta Boidin, Administration Trainee who juggles work experience with school and TAFE studies, and Olivia Graham, assisting our Volunteer Coordinator to manage and support the dozens of terrific NSS volunteers who are involved in refugee support work.

What a great heart this city has!

A good note to finish on. My sincere thanks to the wonderful people around me, colleagues, clients, volunteers.



SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM

Ms Violetta Walsh
Chief Executive Officer
Special Projects Team Leader

Ms Lulu Tantos
Assistant Chief Executive Officer
Registered Migration Agent

Ms Irina Lupish
Registered Migration Agent

Ms Kiri Hata
Coordinator
Complex Case Support (CCS)



Immigration Advice & Assistance Scheme

Lulu Tantos (Reg.#0318123) & **Irina Lupish** (Reg.#0428428)

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

Northern Settlement Services Ltd (NSS) has been providing quality immigration advice and assistance to clients in Newcastle, the Hunter Region and its catchment area for over 15 years.

In the last year the service has been provided by two highly trained and experienced Registered Migration Agents, Deputy Director Lulu Tantos and Irina Lupish.

As in previous years, the service has been provided to two distinct client groups:

- IAAAS (Immigration Advice & Application Assistance Scheme) eligible clients; and
- Fee paying clients

NSS is one of 23 DIAC (Department of Immigration and Citizenship) funded IAAAS providers around Australia providing professional assistance, free of charge, to the most vulnerable and needy visa applicants, to help with the completion and submission of visa applications, liaison with the department, and advice on complex immigration matters.

Persons eligible for Application Assistance include all protection visa applicants in detention, and the most disadvantaged protection visa applicants and other visa applicants in the community. Advice sessions are designed for disadvantaged visa applicants, prospective visa applicants or sponsors in the community.

What counts as disadvantage?

A 'Disadvantaged Person' is one who is in financial hardship and disadvantaged due to:

- non-English speaking background, youth, or other cultural issues such as gender barriers preventing assistance;
- illiteracy in main language of country of origin;
- remote location;
- physical or psychological disability, including from past torture or trauma; or
- physical or psychological harm resulting from family violence.

The scheme has provided advice and assistance to 284 eligible clients and to 2 community groups.

In addition to the IAAAS the past year has seen the Agents providing quality, professional services on over 600 occasions to clients from 56 culturally diverse backgrounds such as China, the Philippines, the Sudan, Thailand, Russia, India, Korea, the UK and Liberia.

Over 700 telephone enquiries have been fielded and advice and assistance provided in a range of visa classes, both temporary and permanent.

Throughout the year the service has been complemented by quarterly outreach visits to the office by experienced Officers from the DIAC Parramatta Office. This service has been invaluable in providing clients in our region with the opportunity to meet and discuss face-to-face their specific needs with a Departmental Officer. Initiated in 1996 as a result of the closure of the local immigration office it continues today and we are most grateful for the support and assistance the Officers from Parramatta provide to our staff and clients. We look forward to maintaining a close working relationship with them in the future.

On a sadder note, it is with heavy heart that I bid farewell and a happy retirement to Irina Lupish, a true friend and wonderful colleague with whom I have been able to share the ups and downs of the job. She will be truly missed.

On a happier note, I am happy to report that local lawyer, Richard Hardy joined the 'immigration team' on a contractual basis from October this year and I look forward to working with him in this challenging area.



To Violetta, the Board of Management and to our colleagues thank you for your friendship, support and guidance throughout the year.



Complex Case Support (CCS)

Kiri Hata

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

Background

In 2008, the Department of Immigration and Citizenship called for tenders to provide Complex Case Support for new or recently arrived refugee clients experiencing extreme hardship and disadvantage in their settlement, above and beyond the more routine services which all refugees have on arrival in this country. The program provides for a level of critical intervention for the most needy, to enable those barriers they face to be addressed as a matter of urgency and for strategies to be developed that will enable them to return to the business of settling in this region.

NSS was successful in winning this tender for the Newcastle and Hunter areas, and has been receiving requests for case intervention plans since November, 2008.

Program Issues and Responses

Clients are facing a range of issues, including legal matters as victims or perpetrators, insecure or inappropriate housing, financial stress, Centrelink benefits being withheld or ceased, elevated physical and psychological health needs, difficulties around child and adult education, domestic violence situations, facing DoCS intervention and appropriate parenting strategies.

Support is provided to individuals and families through a range of means. These can include interagency casework meetings to agree strategies; family conferencing; support through court processes and arranging access to legal advice; facilitating parent meetings with schools; linking clients into community support networks for day to day needs; and working with a team of staff and volunteers to work on urgent housing issues. Sometimes, all of these services were required for one client family.

Various NSS programs are accessed and casework support for specific purposes is provided by staff working with families, young children and with the African Team. Volunteer support is mobilized through the volunteer coordinator, with in-home tutoring being provided to 4 families. Two families have also been linked into the DoCS Brighter Futures program for two years.

Table 1: Statistics for Complex Case Support (CCS)

Total CCS Cases contracted to NSS to date	10
Number of cases completed and exited	3
Cases requiring revised / increased support	3
Current active cases	7

Table 2: Total client numbers involved in Complex Case Support

Families	8
Males	3
Females	9
Children	33

Conclusion

This program has the capacity to greatly improve the outcomes for the most disadvantaged of our client group. It encourages us to work more closely with many other agencies, and has seen the growth of interagency case management of specific families, where NSS takes the lead role in ensuring best practice and timely intervention. Clients are routinely expressing great satisfaction with these relationships under CCS and believe they have been empowered and a party in their own success in dealing with the issues they have faced. The increased resources available to achieve these outcomes have also ensured the general services of the centre are not undermined due to the high needs and complexity of service delivery.

I have found this work to be most rewarding, the work environment dynamic and exciting, and am truly grateful for the full support, advice and encouragement of Violetta and the NSS management and administrative team.

Kia kaha, e hoa. (Stay strong, friends)



RURAL TEAM

Mr Alex Burns
Rural Projects Team Leader
Rural Support Project

Ms Rose Oku
Settlement Support Worker
Hunter Welfare Outreach Settlement Grants Program

Ms Judith Roberts
Settlement Support Worker
New England Settlement Grants Program
(Armidale)

Mr Amalin Sundarevej
Settlement Support Worker
New England Settlement Grants Program
(Tamworth)

Ms Katie Wright
Settlement Support Worker
New England Settlement Grants Program
(Inverell)



Rural Support Settlement Grants Program

Alex Burns (Team Leader)

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

Introduction

This project provides team leadership, assistance, mentoring and resourcing to NSS and other rural DIAC funded SGP projects who provide support to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees, family and other permanent visa holders who have low English language proficiency and may be experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement. In the rural and regional areas of northern and western NSW.

Support is varied and is provided to projects in a range of diverse locations on the North Coast (Lismore and Coffs Harbour); Mid North Coast (Manning Valley and Port Macquarie); New England (Armidale, Tamworth and Inverell); Central Western and Far Western (Orange, Bathurst and Dubbo); Central Coast and in the Hunter Region including Newcastle.

The potential client group comprises some 8000 new arrivals, 12 percent who are refugees and humanitarian entrants. The growth of the refugee population in Northern and Western NSW reflects two forms of settlement. The first of these is the direct settlement of people on the 200 series of Visas including sponsored settlement under the 202 Visa. The second form of settlement is via secondary movement, especially of African refugees looking for employment or a quieter life style for their families. This has seen substantial numbers of people move to Orange and Bathurst, Tamworth and Coffs Harbour where in the last 2 instances work has been sought in abattoirs and in fruit picking (blueberries).

Although skilled migration into rural areas has increased, the largest number of migrants is arriving on Family visa, as spouses. Numbers of these find isolation a major issue and lack of social support to help maintain them and the SGP project workers provide group support as these new arrival integrate into local communities.

Achievements

Casework and Orientation Support

As this project backs up other projects to support their casework and also provides some direct casework Table 1 provides information on this and other project work as recorded in DIAC's Online Settlement Client Activity Recording (OSCAR) work.

Table 1: OSCARs for the Rural Support Grant 2008-09

Clients	Case contacts	Short Contacts	Group Sessions
31	36	9812	125

Direct Work with Rural Based Projects

Although many of the SGP project have great competencies with their casework sometimes strategies are required with specific clients to address major problems. This is where this project counsels and mentors, advising project workers on how to best address these client problems. In these 12 months, issues like the lack of services using interpreters in their dealings with our client target group leading to penalties, the lack of proper pre-lending investigations by financial institutions and the like, highlight some of these areas where this project's skills and advice are provided.

Contact and support to the individual rural based SGP projects comprises visits and regular phone contact and more and more through the use of emails. The number of visits to each Rural SGP project is listed below in Table 2. As will be seen the largest number of visits was to the NSS managed projects, and this included the project's Rural Team Leader role for NSS. Central Coast became a NSS project at the end of 2008 and some of the visits to this location included setting in place appropriate accountability measures.

Table 2: Face to Face Visits to Regional and Rural SGP Projects

SGP Location	Visits	SGP Location	Visits
Wyoming/Central Coast	13	Tamworth	10
Inverell	5	Armidale	8
Manning Valley	2	Lismore	2
Woolgoolga	2	Lightning Ridge	3
Dubbo	3	Orange	3
Bathurst	3	Coffs Harbour	3

Other "hot spots", included Tamworth, where the incumbent SGP worker left after 2 years and a locum SGP worker came into operation and needed great support due to issues around the development of a more permanent home for the project, Inverell as the first worker in this location suffered family loss and was unable to continue, and Lismore and especially Orange where the growth of Refugee settlement required greater support for the local SGP project workers.

Other Work

Other work included convening or supporting the strong Multicultural Interagency and Multicultural Network base which now exists across northern and western NSW with 8 forums of this nature. This allowed SGP projects to raise their profiles, have other services present on their service operation and to maintain and plan new services to reach the SGP target group. The project also participates in other forums to gain information on services and referral process and in planning and policy development. These include: the DoCS state Ethnic Affairs Advisory group, the DADHC Hunter Central Coast regional group, the Hunter Consultative Water forum, the NSW Hunter DET. Equity meeting and so on. Newcastle, Central Coast and Hunter Rural forums also were attended.

Altogether, a busy but productive year.



Hunter Welfare Outreach Settlement Grants Program

Rose Oku

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Hunter Welfare Outreach SGP project provides support services to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees and migrants, especially women who are experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

Casework

During the year the project provide much face to face casework for the client group and especially in the provision of support for women in diverse parts of the Hunter to attend Family Court, access English and employment training courses and to attend Centrelink, community health programs and tenancy services. Tables 1 and 2 provide a picture of this work which is based on the DIAC Online Settlement Client data (OSCAR) for this project.

Table 1: Casework & Group Work Sessions for Hunter Outreach SGP project 2008-2009

OSCAR 1 Clients	OSCAR 2: Casework Contact	OSCAR 3 Short casework	OSCAR 4 Group Work Sessions
101	465	3974	28 (413 participants)

Table 2 Clients served across the Hunter Region

Location	No of clients	Location	No of clients
Singleton	20	Charlestown	15
Cessnock	15	Maitland	10
Belmont	8	Raymond Terrace	8
Muswellbrook	8	Nelson Bay	3
Toronto	2	Salt ash	2
Tanilba Bay	2	Shoal bay	2
Hamilton (NSS Office)	3	Woodrising	2

Major Issues Identified during work with the Client group

As can be seen from Table 1 the project served 101 clients. Many individual issues were raised while other issues arose with group work and information sessions.



These other issues relate to:

- Documents – filling-in forms etc
- Employment, Education & Training –availability, accessibility, eligibility & resources
- Housing and tenancy
- Childcare – particularly costs & availability
- Health – Women’s health
- Transport
- English classes & access issues
- Social isolation
- Centrelink
- Domestic violence
- Immigration, visa & Citizenship
- Legal issues

Table 2 shows that many of those experiencing the above issues were found across the Hunter Region in areas like Singleton, Cessnock and Charlestown.

Group Work

Information sessions were held throughout the year in partnership with other services like Community Health, Centrelink, the Tenancy Advice Service and the NSS Migration Agent. A pool of volunteers was also developed from the client group with the support of the Rural Support project and some Councils.

Networking and other Forums

Much of the success of the project has been due to its ability to network with other organisations. This offered good client outcomes through the project worker’s developing knowledge on specific services through these networking relationships. Other networking was through formal meetings, inter-agencies and other forums and the project worker was able to share information on the target group, refer sensitive case work to familiar services and to develop a strong base on issues that impacted on the new arrival clients. Networking also included managing 3 meetings of the Hunter Rural multicultural network held in Salamander Bay, Cessnock, Maitland, and Muswellbrook. Maitland Council addressed the Network on its Social Plan so as to improve service delivery to the migrant community in the Maitland area and on its work with African Refugees.

Other networking occurred with participation in the Lake Macquarie, Port Stephens, Cessnock, Upper Hunter and Singleton local government area Interagencies, the Cessnock Family Insight graduation, the Hunter New England Area Health Mental Health Multicultural Access Committee and the quarterly Centrelink forum. An Expo was also held with the Office of Fair Trading at Morisset Shopping Centre. Nova accommodation and support for clients led to increased networking with other services.

Finally, staff case worker meetings involved discussions on difficult cases experienced by individual workers this networking allowed workers to share the ideas with other staff to achieve good outcomes for the target group.

Training

A major area of importance is the continued development of skills to help in delivering the project. Appropriate training for each project worker was encouraged and was particularly important to the project worker. Training included DIAC training in use of OSCAR, networking, working on the frontline with clients, family harmony awareness, Settlement Services in Complex Environments and Evaluation Training. Other training included: healthy living for families and Property issues training as organized by family law (NGO Training), working with diversity and developing a more accessible service by DoCS, suicide prevention training in community organized by the Wesley Mission Australia, Housing appeals committee training, while NSS provided a Staff planning day, and training sessions on OH&S.

Altogether it has been a busy year with good outcomes for the project’s refugee and migrant client group.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Armidale)

Judith Roberts

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Armidale office continues to provide settlement information, referrals to other agencies, community capacity building, service planning and development for new arrivals, including migrants and humanitarian entrants, and the dependents of skilled migrants. The humanitarian entrants face multiple barriers to settlement and high levels of socio-economic disadvantage. Most of the client group consist of female humanitarian entrants who are single parents with large families. Their issues relate to access to education, housing and child care. This group of clients has required intensive settlement support as many also experience distress around support for family members still in Africa.

Table 1 provides an indication of the work of the project based on the Online Settlement Client Activity Recording (OSCAR) as required by DIAC. As the table shows nearly 800 client contacts took place at the Armidale base during 2008-09.

Table 1 Client Statistics

Type	Number
OSCAR 1	25
OSCAR 2	757
OSCAR 3	5,617
OSCAR 4	153

Client Services: Overall client issues identified were: accommodation, family relationships/ breakdowns, access to mental health support, employment, transport, debt issues, access to driving lessons, health access and transport problems and lack of knowledge of the health system, homework support, access and equity to services and access to childcare. The main client group of this service are Humanitarian 202 visa holders with the next group being migrants on spouse visas. Many of the women face the added challenges as sole parents due to their husband's return to the country of origin, death, or family breakdown. The need for support with legal issues due to debt, but mostly to family breakdown was noted. Young men are also quite a disadvantaged refugee and migrant group, whose main issues include lack of employment, access to driving lessons, housing, and access to education and training. Contact with the ESL students at TAFE also continues to provide an opportunity for people to seek assistance or advice in an informal way as well as raising awareness of the SGP.

The Tamworth Migrant Women's Network: Table 1 highlights group work – OSCAR 4, and the Tamworth Migrant Women's Network was an important part of the group work during the year. The women attending the group in 2008/2009 were Filipinos, Chinese, Malaysian and to a lesser extent this year Sudanese women as these began moving away from Tamworth. Meetings have included information sessions from Centrelink, a visit to Tamworth Community Health and a "Stress Less Day" provided by the Transcultural Outreach Program (TRROP). TRROP also hosted a Wellbeing session that was well received and attended by the group as well as women from Armidale. These events were an exciting opportunity for the women from the two cities to meet and network with each other. Members of the TMWN attended the Migrant and Refugee Employment Expo in Armidale and the Tamworth DET Farrar High School Harmony Day event where they participated as 'talking books'.

In June, to mark Refugee Week the Tamworth Women's and Children's Refuge was the venue for a multicultural lunch. Women from Armidale also attended the event. The TMWN has been generously supported by the Tamworth Women's Refuge over many years and a very dedicated volunteer, Kay Ledwos.

Outreach to Inverell: While Daisy Brown was on maternity leave the Armidale SGP project worker supported Inverell clients. However, since Katie Wright's appointment to the position, support from Armidale has been in an advisory capacity or in shared events. For example, in August 2008 a group of women from Armidale travelled to Inverell for the Women's Health Expo. One of the main reasons for bringing the two communities together was to breakdown isolation.

Other Information Sessions: The North England and West Tenancy and Advocacy and Advice Service provided an intensive session to the client group about housing and tenancy issues. An information session with Armidale police and Armidale Sanctuary and the Sudanese community provided information on the discipline of children in families and was a way of opening the dialogue between the Sudanese community and police. The highlight of the year was the New England Migrant and Refugee Employment Expo. NSS worked collaboratively with many other services, community groups and DIAC over many months to hold the expo. Over 100 people attended this event.

Meetings and Committee representation: I am involved in a broad range of networks through attendance at various meetings. NSS in Armidale also works closely with the region's Refugee Health Nurse. NSS in Armidale has been able to support the work that STARTTS counsellors from Coffs Harbour are doing on a regular basis in Armidale.

Refugee Week Events: Refugee Week events in the New England were held to include the AMES 'Freedom from Fear' exhibition (*pictured, right*). NSS worked with the AMES, DET and the local community and local Refugees were included. The Tamworth event was at the Women's Refuge and the Armidale event was attended by approximately 100 people and held in the town hall. Many Refugees and their supporters enjoyed the celebration. These events were supported by the Refugee Council of Australia and other local partners including Northern Inland Regional Development Board, Armidale Dumaresq Council, Armidale Sanctuary, the Adult Migrant English Program, Department of Education Training and NSS.



Summary

There have been many highlights over the past year and all achievements have been enhanced by the wonderful connections made with clients, NSS volunteers and the wider New England community.

Thanks to other NSS colleagues who have supported me over the past year.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Tamworth) **Amalin Sundaravej**

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Tamworth base of the New England Settlement Grant Project (SGP) is a 3 day a week service and provides support services to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees, family and other permanent visa holders who have low English language proficiency and may be experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and other misfortunes encountered in their first five years of settlement in the Tamworth area. The services offered include: direct client services; settlement information; referral to other agencies where appropriate; building capacity to become independent and confident in seeking service support and working with other agencies and services; and to ensure that services are accessible and equitable to the SGP target population.

The Tamworth work has also addressed the lack of supportive networks, accessibility to mainstream services, assisting the refugee and migrant community's development and promoting a sense of self-identity, belonging and participation with the broader Tamworth community. The project also raises awareness among mainstream service providers to assist them to become more responsive to the needs of the target group in the Tamworth area.

Overview of 2008-09

During the 2008-09 period the Tamworth base changed personnel as Home Phanoraj left and Amalin Sundaravej became the project worker. Table 1 lists the project work during 2008-09; this is then followed by Amalin's report on her first 2 months with NSS at Tamworth.

Table 1: Client Contact & project work during 2008-9

New Clients	Client Contacts	Telephone calls	Group Work
28	118	1088	24 sessions (170 participants)

The 118 client contact work covered a range of issues including: Citizenship, Brighter Futures, Health, Tamworth Women's Refuge, Housing, Court Support, Home Tutoring, Driver's licenses, Overseas Trade Recognition and employment opportunities. Referrals were made to appropriate services such as Department of Housing, Real Estate Agents, Tamworth Base Hospital, Tamworth Local Court, Trans cultural Mental Health, Job Network services and Centrelink.

Group work varied but concentrated on support to African Refugees. As Table 1 shows 24 group sessions took place mostly with young Africans with average number of participants totalling 5-6 people. Topics covered included: Citizenship, Driving and buying a car, driving laws, Health and sexual health, the meaning of AVO and laws in a new Land. Several partnerships were developed with other services and especially the regional Health Services and the Refugee Health Nurse.

Amalin's work

Table 2 is a summary of the background of Amalin's clients over a 2 month period. Most people were from Sudan, refugees who have sought work in the industries found in Tamworth or have wanted a better (safer) environment for their children.

Table 2: Clients by Birthplace Background

Background of Clients	Number
Sudanese	1
Zimbabwean	2
Filipino	4
Swiss	1
Thai	1
India	1
Total	10

Settlement issues

During this reporting period, issues encountered were: Need to look for employment and all forms of temporary employment (casual, part-time) in and around Tamworth. There seems to be a preference towards working at the abattoir for the men and egg picking and egg packing for the women; the citizenship test, the need for English language training at TAFE and practicing English conversation, assistance in resume writing, information on IELTS requirements; home tutoring; Assistance to get their overseas skills get recognized and domestic or family violence.

Employment opportunities

In Tamworth, the abattoirs and chicken processing plants are the two major sources of employment that continue to attract the African (male) community to the area as well as the new male migrants. Other migrant communities, and especially Filipino women are employed more widely in chicken hatchery plants, nursing and age care, while the Chinese, Thai, Indian, Lebanese and Vietnamese new arrivals tend to find work in local restaurants, catering business and service stations.

Employment opportunities can vary because of language barriers and lack of or no recognition of skills. There is a case of underemployment as some or most of the new migrants have either a college diploma or a university degree, although their fluency in the English language communication skills is limited and is yet another hindrance causing yet an additional barrier in their search for employment.

Networking

I have attended: 1 multicultural interagency meeting (Armidale); Met and discussed citizenship issues with NSS' Citizenship project worker, facilitated meeting for 4 new migrant clients with DIAC officers, met and discussed refugee health issues with the Hunter New England Refugee health nurse; Met and was briefed by the project coordinator of the Tamworth Rural and Remote Outreach Project (TRROP) re her project; the Tamworth Women's and Children's Refuge on a DV case; met with Centrelink in Tamworth to introduce NSS presence and as a service provider.

Other Issues

Several office relocations occurred due to the Department of Education rebuilding and therefore rehousing this project to a more client friendly office.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Inverell)

Katie Wright

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Inverell project provides a support service to refugees and family stream migrants within the local area most whom are disadvantaged often have low English language proficiency and may be experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement. The Inverell office operated 7 hours a week during the 2008-2009 period. Primarily, providing settlement information and orientation, capacity building and social integration. Referrals to main stream service providers have been vital and a strong relationship has been founded ensuring that services are accessible and equitable to the client group.

Client Services

The client group at this point in the project originate from the African Countries of Sudan and Kenya. A diverse range of issues have been addressed including, but not limited to the following: employment, special educational needs, lack of use of interpreter and translator services, as well as a lack of health services, social participation, existence of isolation from main family group, problems with relationships, transportation, financial management, legal, counselling, childcare, tenancy issues, managing neighbour conflict, accommodation, education & training and general document assistance.

Significant support and assistance was provided to a family group who were referred to and subsequently became a Complex Case. As part of this process the client decided to relocate to another town. Although management of the complex case was awarded to another provider the Inverell SGP project facilitated the logistics of the move and coordinated with many other service providers to ensure a smooth transition.

Network and Community Relations

As this is a new project location, participation and attendance of community meetings has been essential. Meetings regularly attended have included Inverell Sanctuary, Inverell Inter-Agency, Inverell Anti-Violence Committee, Love Bites Committee and DOCS.

In order to raise community awareness of this project and establish valuable networks within the local area, promotion and an introduction of NSS has been delivered to large number of agencies service providers and organisations. Flyers and brochures have been distributed throughout the local area and are prominently displayed in many relevant contact points for our target client group.

A sound relationship has been built with education providers e.g. TAFE and local schools, Police Department, Health Professionals, Local Counselling services, Inverell Refuge, Job Agencies, Centrelink, STARTTS and other counselling services, DOCS, Sanctuary, Inverell Shire Council, Members of Parliament, Religious Groups, Community Groups and many other people and providers that play an important role in the settlement of our clients.

Community Events

NSS provided a morning tea to celebrate **Harmony Day, 2009**. It was held at the local TAFE and was well attended by approximately 40 students and teachers. The local paper covered the event and an article including photos went to print.

NSS coordinated another morning tea, this time it was to celebrate **Refugee Week 2009** and it was held at the Riverside Restaurant. Nearly 80 people came along to support the Inverell Refugee Community, including the Mayor and General Manager of Council, religious leaders, education providers, Sanctuary members, many service providers and a whole diverse range of community members.

Our guest speaker was one of the first refugees to arrive in Inverell in the 1980's. She spoke of her experience and life journey since migrating from Vietnam. A highlight of the morning was the unveiling of the photo's that were to become part of the **NSW AMES Photo Exhibition 'Freedom from Fear'**. A total of 3 participants from the Inverell Refugee Community took part in this wonderful exhibition. 2 ladies from Sudan and 1 man from Vietnam kindly agreed to share their personal stories and be photographed. The photographer –Abby Horwood donated her exceptional talent and valuable services.

NSW AMES Photo Exhibition – 'Freedom from Fear', coordinated in Inverell by NSS. This was a hugely successful and rewarding community event. Opening night at the local Inverell Art Gallery saw an overwhelming number of people show their support for this awakening exhibition. The Deputy Mayor opened the event which was followed by a brief explanation and overview of purpose by myself. The final speech of the night was given by an 8 year old school student, who was recently awarded for her public speaking ability and whose topic was 'Refugees in Australia'. Her innocence and compassion left many overwhelmed and impacted significantly on the purpose of this event. The local newspaper, Inverell Times dedicated front page to the event and followed with a full page of colour photos and article.



Training and Development

During 2008-2009 I undertook several training courses, which have certainly enhanced my ability to work with clients. I completed a 'Prepare to Mentor' course and 'Love Bites' training which relates to Domestic Violence and Sexual Assault. I have attended several information sessions and workshops relating to health and education. In March I attended the DIAC conference in Sydney.

Programme Development

The project in Inverell is looking forward to a productive 2009-2010 period. Office hours will be extended to 14 hours a week and this will support the expansion of this service. The **Inverell Migrant Network (IMN)** is in the process of being established. It is a friendly and supportive group that will provide opportunities, outings and general social participation to our target group. Service providers will be invited to provide information sessions that will assist in addressing identified needs. The IMN is hoping to establish a market stall in the early period of 2010 and this will be a motivating and empowering project for the group participants to work upon.

Conclusion

I am so proud to be a part of NSS and I believe the work we do is vital not only for the clients we support but for the communities they must live within.

I would like to take this opportunity to say a sincere thank you to my supervisor Alex Burns who has provided many a moment of wisdom and unconditional support. I would also like to make a special thanks to my co-worker Judy Roberts who I would be lost without.



AGED SERVICES TEAM

Ms Sue (Slavica) Hristov
Aged Services Team Leader
Coordinator
Community Aged Care Packages

Ms Lupe Fonua
Coordinator
Community Aged Care Packages

Ms Tima 'Oto
Coordinator
Community Aged Care Packages
Hunter Multicultural Respite Service

Ms Enza Di Stefano
Coordinator
Community Visitors Scheme

Ms Valerie Woodman
Project Officer
Multicultural Access Project - Hunter



Community Aged Care Packages Sue Hristov (Team Leader), Tima 'Oto & Lupe Fonua

Funded by Commonwealth Department
of Health & Ageing

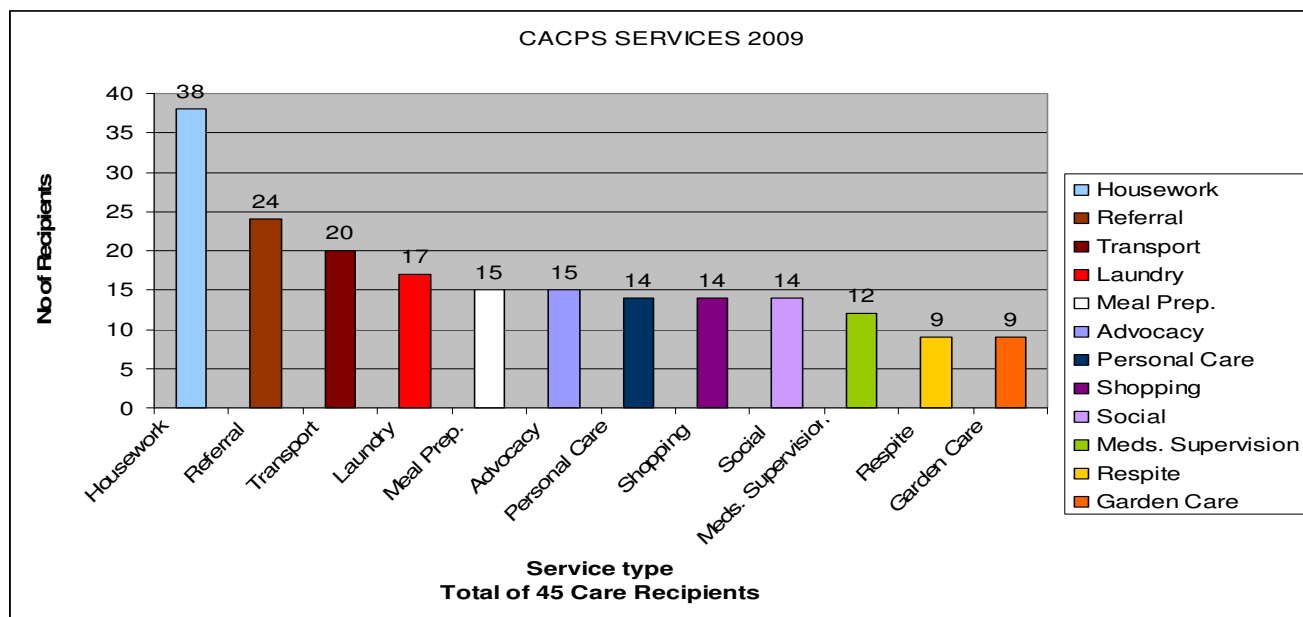
The Community Aged Care Project is in its 9th year of successful operation and continues to provide home based care and assistance to vulnerable; frail aged people who have complex care needs.

Our target group is older people from Culturally and Linguistically Diverse Backgrounds (CALD) in the Hunter region, who need assistance with the tasks of daily living to improve their quality of life and enable them to stay living at home as long as possible. We are currently funded to provide assistance to 42 people- however prudent financial management has enabled us to increase that number by an additional 3 people (unfunded).

CARE RECIPIENT PROFILE

Our care recipients come from 15 different cultural backgrounds: Italian(13); Greek (7); Polish (5); Slovenian (4); Macedonian (3); Sri Lankan (2); Chinese (2); Ukrainian (2); Vietnamese (1); Japanese (1); Guyanan (1); Russian (1); German (1); Serbian (1); Hungarian (1)- and they live across the Hunter Region (with the majority in Newcastle and Lake Macquarie).

- 34 Female -11 Male- age range from 97 to 72 years old
- 20 living at home alone - 23 have a carer living with them
- 2 double packages- care provided to both husband and wife
- 12 having a diagnosis of dementia (4 more people than last year)



SERVICES PROVIDED

We currently provide 140 hrs of direct assistance per week- an average of 3 hrs per care recipient – some require only 1-2 hrs per week and others with complex care needs and/or those who do not have live in carers or other family/support networks require significantly more- one as high as 13-14 hours per week.

The past year has seen a very small drop in the number of people (19% as compared to 20% last year) who required a higher level of care than a CACP program is generally designed to provide- about 5.5 hours per week. Having a mixture of both low care and higher care clients has allowed us to meet our duty of care obligations and provide the level of care needed until other options such as EACH (Extended Aged Care at Home) or residential care, become available.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

The overall responsibility for Program management/ Service Coordination falls to the Coordinators while direct service provision (care workers who go to people's homes) is contracted from reputable agencies- this model continues to serve our organisation well. The agreements in place with 7 agencies has given us access to a larger pool of workers (bilingual if required) as well as enabling us to offer people choice e.g. gender of workers (particularly in cases of personal care) etc. Tailoring services to meet individual needs is a cornerstone of CACP and this model has allowed us to meet those needs in a culturally appropriate way,

CASE MANAGEMENT

Another essential element of the CACP Program is the case management/ongoing monitoring role of Coordinators who are available not only during office hours but on a 24hours -7days a week on-call arrangement - something that is very much appreciated by care recipients/ families. At times managing complex care needs has required daily/very regular monitoring/responding to deteriorating health/ dementia/challenging behaviours/carer stress/family conflict issues. While this has often proved challenging, it has also been a major source of job satisfaction for Coordinators.- there is nothing more rewarding than seeing the positive and very practical difference our work makes to the quality of people's lives every day. For example, one clients' feedback says: "Sincere gratitude for all your help, support, advice over the years I certainly couldn't have coped without you & your care workers being there for me- your understanding, your empathy and quick response with additional, help in times of crisis was very much appreciated- Mum's fortune in acquiring a CACP with Migrant Resource Centre 7years ago greatly assisted her to continue living on her own as long as possible- your work does make a big difference to people's lives"

The past year has been a busy but rewarding one for the CACP Project – all made immeasurably easier through the continuing support from the Board of Management, Violetta and fellow colleagues/service providers. Many thanks- especially to Enza di Stefano for looking after Sue's clients so well and to Lupe Fonua for taking on the Aged Care Team Leader role, while Sue was away.



Hunter Multicultural Respite Service

Tima 'Oto

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Homecare
- Home & Community Care Program (HACC)

Hunter Multicultural Respite Service (HMRS) provides respite care for frail older people or people with dementia from non-English speaking backgrounds experiencing difficulty in attending Day Care Centres. The service provides a culturally appropriate worker to assist with care of clients at Day Care Centres to sustain their placement at Day Care and to provide their carers some respite.

Model of Service Provision

HMRS is staffed by one part-time coordinator (3 days per week) and direct care services are provided on a brokerage model, i.e. care workers are contracted as needed from other existing providers such as Uniting Care, Home Care and Extra Care and Novacare. The brokerage model has proven to be an efficient and effective model, as it enables the project to have a wider pool of workers to choose from and enables the service to better meet the cultural and linguistic needs of particular clients.

Services provided

Throughout 2009 a total of 27 clients have had weekly services of between 2-8 hours per week, including transport for 3 clients. Two clients attend more than one Day Care Centre. A total of 2 new clients have commenced services since the beginning of this year and 7 clients have either unfortunately died throughout the year or ceased service mainly due to placement into permanent residential care. All clients have been formally assessed initially and reviewed after 6 months of service. There are no clients on the waiting list and every client referred has been offered service.

In 2009 the Project has:

- Provided 4122 hrs of service- about 14 hr per client per month
- contracted 20 care workers for direct service provision

Table 1: Day Care Centres & Clients

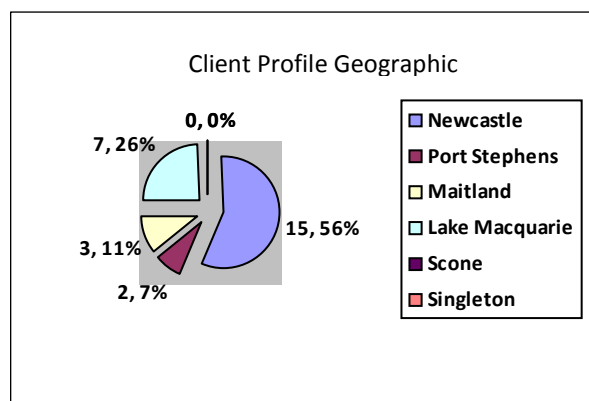
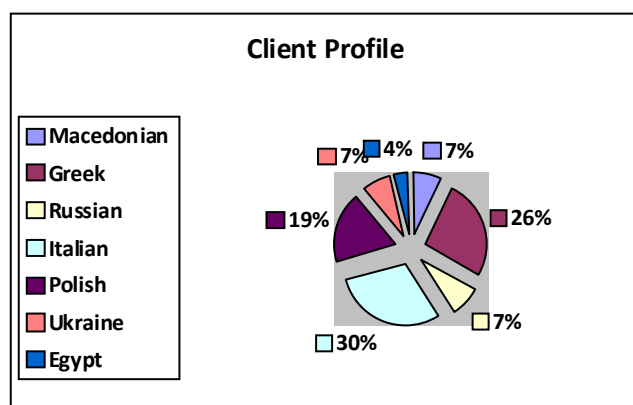
Day Care Centre	No of clients per Day Care Centres at 30/10/2009
Greek Day Care	6
Holy Apostles Day Care	3
Macedonian Day Care	1
Italian Day Care	5
Polish Day Care	5
Maitland Multicultural Friendship Group	3
Alkira Dementia Centre, Toronto	0
Wattle Grove Dementia Day Care	1
Allawah Day Centre, Wallsend	1
East Lake Macquarie Dementia service	1
Southlakes Day Care, Morisset	1
TOTAL	27

Multicultural Dementia Support Group- support for carers

This year the meetings were changed from Wednesday to Tuesday to accommodate members who were not able to attend on Wednesday - this will be reviewed for next year's meetings. The service coordinates the monthly meeting of the group (jointly with Community Options) on the second Tuesday of the month. Throughout the year we have had speakers and information sessions to assist and support carers. 'Dancing with the Stars' was the highlight of this year's Carer's Week (organised by the Commonwealth Carer Respite Centre) and was attended by members of the Dementia Support group. We also organised 2 bus trips to Cabramatta and Chinatown which went well.

Table 2: Client Characteristics

Gender		Age			Client condition	
Male	Female	54-69	70-79	80-89	Dementia	Frail Aged
4	23	6	17	4	14	11



Administration

- A DADHC grant of \$2651 was used to purchase ethno-specific resources and mobility aids such as wheelchairs/walking frames/ games- to improve client access
- New agreements and risk assessments of Day care Centres were signed off throughout the year to follow up from DADHC Review/ Action plan
- MDS database was updated to the new HADS format and data successfully transferred / statistics compiled and sent to DADHC quarterly.

Training / conferences attended throughout the year include:

- Experiencing Dementia Workshop, Alzheimer's Australia, Hamilton
- Aged Care Workshop – Sydney Olympic Park

Meetings attended on a regular basis include:

- Quality and Team meetings, Aged Care Team Monthly Meeting
- Hunter Ethnic Aged Services Network
- HACC services and Community Services Network quarterly meetings
- Dementia Interagency meetings & Upper Hunter Interagency

I would like to thank the Board and my colleagues at NSS for their assistance and support, which has enabled the service to consolidate and build successfully throughout 2009.



Community Visitors Scheme

Enza Di Stefano

Funded by Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing

Introduction:

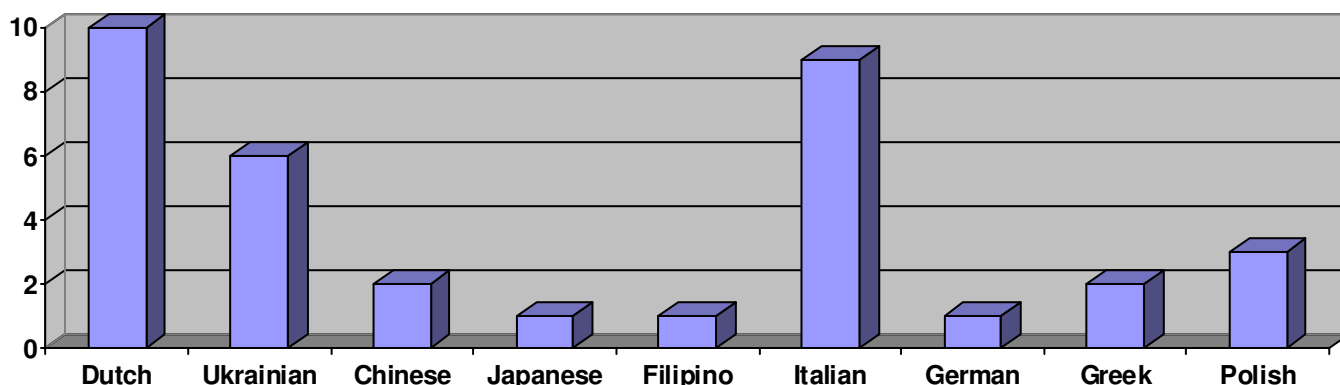
The NSS Community Visitors Scheme (CVS) provides socially isolated residents of aged care facilities in the Lower Hunter, who are from Culturally / Linguistically Diverse Backgrounds (CALD), a better quality of life through one on one volunteer visits. Over the past twelve months 13 Facilities have been visited with a total of 824 visits to 35 residents and over 13,700 kilometres travelled.

Community Visitor Recruitment and Turnover:

Recruitment is an on-going process and during the year 18 visitors were available : 4 visitors go to more than one facility - due to the need of a specific language/ cultural background; and 5 visitors visit more than one resident (separately – on a one to one basis) at the same facility- again due to the need of a specific language/ cultural background/ the presence of dementia- 3 visitors resigned during the year; two due to ill health and one due to the resident having severe dementia which caused the visitor much distress (this resident has not been able to have a replacement visitor).

All visitors are contacted at least once a month either through a phone call or by mail to maintain communication and support.

Resident Cultural Background



Orientation Activities: Individual orientation for prospective visitors including Police Checks was provided; a well received dementia flyer was developed in response to volunteers experiencing difficulties in communicating with residents with dementia; a Grief and Loss session was held in conjunction with Wesley Mission; a CVS Dementia Training on different stages of dementia and communicating with people who have dementia was conducted by Alzheimer's Australia.

Promotional Activities:

Successful promotional activities with community groups/ Nursing Home Activity Officers have attracted new volunteers as well as increasing the number of referrals from existing & previously unvisited facilities. Attendance at an Aged Care Expo was a good opportunity to showcase the program and liaise with other workers in the field. As well, a CD advertising the project was developed with Hunter Volunteer Centre and is being promoted in the local Community Radio.

Networking:

Participated in 3 regional CVS Network Meetings & NSW CVS Forum- a good opportunity to discuss issues of concern /share resources/seek advice from the Department- 'the definition of an active volunteer' is though a continuing concern.

Networking with other CVS auspices resulted in 2 new visitor referrals. As well, Nursing Home communication/feedback protocols regarding residents who have passed away have been put in place alleviating any future stress on volunteers.

Special Events acknowledging the invaluable contribution of visitors

The combined Volunteer Christmas Lunch/CVS 15 Year Celebration was a great success. Each volunteer received a ' Friendship calendar' as a small thankyou/Christmas gift - an inaugural visitor was also presented with a badge for 15 years service – an astounding achievement considering this visitor is now 83 years young. A bus trip was organised to historic Morpeth for Volunteer week

Benefits of the Scheme:

- The principal benefit of the Scheme is that Visitors play an integral role in easing the social and cultural isolation experienced by residents who may not have family living close by/ who lack extended support networks
- Having a Visitor from a similar cultural background also allows residents to maintain a link to the community through sharing of news/current activities in the community.

Identified Difficulties:

The main difficulty remains the recruitment of suitable visitors from the diminishing ethnic population. This has necessitated adopting the strategy of a number of visitors seeing more than one resident in the same facility and often in different facilities - this has enabled us to provide support to a larger number of residents who would otherwise miss out. As well, visiting people of advanced age/ serious health issues e.g dementia, can have a considerable emotional toll on visitors- ongoing counselling and support from the Coordinator is essential.

Satisfaction with the Service Provided:

Feedback received indicates that the service is most appreciated and valued by CVS clients and Aged Care Facilities (as they have few bilingual staff members). The NSS CVS is able to support communication within the facility environment through the use of their language skills and the friendships they establish.



Multicultural Access Project - Hunter

Valerie Woodman

Funded by Ageing, Disability and Home Care -NSW Department of Human Services

- Home and Community Care Program (HACC)

This is a new project funded in the 2008-2009 financial period. I commenced in the position on 14 October 2009. The aim of the service is to promote and ensure equitable access to HACC funded services for culturally and Linguistically Diverse (CALD) people who are frail aged, people with a disability and their carers living in the Hunter region. The role of the service is to provide information, referral, service support, social research, strategic planning, community development and education.

The Service area comprises the Cessnock, Lake Macquarie, Maitland, Muswellbrook, Newcastle, Port Stephens, Singleton and Upper Hunter local government areas

The service will provide strategic advice; information and assistance to multicultural and mainstream HACC funded services to improve outcomes for the target group of (CALD) people who are frail aged, people with a disability and their carers. Research will be undertaken to identify their needs in order to inform the ADHC/HACC planning process so that services will adapt to cultural differences, be responsive to specific needs and reflect local CALD demographics. Information and advice will be provided to CALD communities to increase their knowledge of HACC funded and other relevant support services. The service will also develop professional networks; facilitate initiatives and partnerships with community services having a commitment to ageing in place, maintaining independence and the well being of carers.

A service brochure has been produced which will be translated in key selected languages. Initial research has been undertaken using Census 2006 data and from this a snapshot of CALD people aged 65+ years for each local government area has been developed. Current data on younger people with a disability and carers is being sourced through Centrelink and state government departments.

A meeting with the Program Officer Planning and Purchasing ADHC was held on 28 October 2009 to clarify key performance indicators, timelines and the future direction of the project. The project worker is attending relevant Interagency and Network meetings across the Hunter to get to know local service providers and has also made contact with the HACC NSW Multicultural Access Program Network and will attend the next meeting on 23 November 2009 to liaise and collaborate with other regional MAP workers.

Key actions for the next three months will be to:

- Establish an Advisory Committee of relevant stakeholders to support the project.
- Investigate the feasibility of re-establishing the Lower and Upper Hunter Ethnic HACC Forums and the Hunter CALD Disability Network.
- Facilitate consultations and research the needs of the Hunter HACC CALD population.

It is a privilege to be working for Northern Settlement Services and to be part of such a professional and committed team.

I am looking forward to a very busy and productive year ahead.



CENTRAL COAST TEAM

Sandra Wingrave
Team Leader
Senior Coordinator
Multicultural Social Support Service

Olivia Fuente
Coordinator
Multicultural Social Support Service

Ms Trudy Wahl
Office Manager
Multicultural Social Support Service

Ms Danielle Habib
Settlement Support Worker
Central Coast - Settlement Grants Program

Ms Pari Batha
Central Coast - Multicultural Family Support Project



Multicultural Social Support Service Central Coast

**Sandra Wingrave (Team Leader) Olivia Fuente
& Trudy Wahl**

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Home Care
– Home & Community Care (HACC) Program

The Multicultural Social Support Service (MSSS) supports CALD people in Wyong & Gosford LGAs who are: frail aged, younger people with a disability, and carers.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

Volunteers provide social support to clients and carers which includes: home visits, telephone calls, taking clients: shopping, banking, to medical appointments etc and supporting clients to attend outings and events, including organised client activity days.

ADMINISTRATION

The following administration tasks have been undertaken throughout the year.

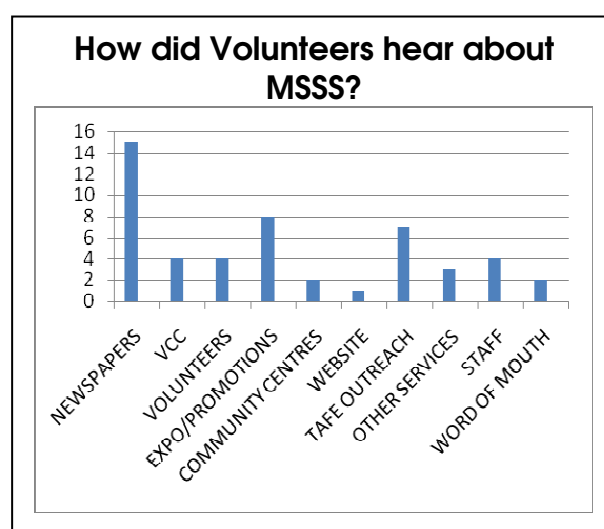
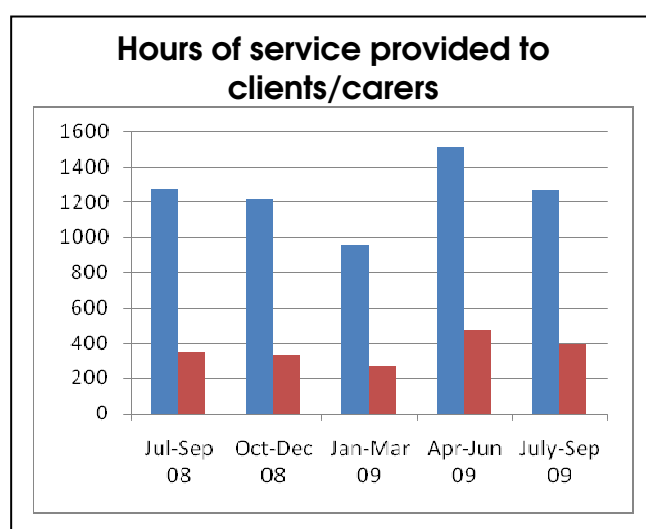
- Monthly media releases inform the community about MSSS, and are also for the purpose of recruiting new Volunteers and clients. 50 Volunteer application kits were sent out, and as a result. 30% of Volunteer applicants found out about the service through advertising in local commercial newspapers, followed closely by 16% through Expos, and 14% through TAFE Outreach.
- Compilation and Distribution of the Volunteer Newsletter.
- Relevant OH&S assessments and processes were carried out as scheduled.
- Processing of Volunteer reimbursements, Client service fees and petty cash balancing.
- At the beginning of the year Trudy was offered to increase her hours of work to accommodate the three new projects at NSS Central Coast - Multicultural Family Support, Settlement Support and Thai Family Welfare.

VOLUNTEERS

- To date, the service has 45 registered Volunteers, 40 of whom are actively involved with clients, and of which, 69% speak languages other than English
- Four Training days and Supervision & Support Meetings have been held throughout the year. Training has included: Caring for Older Clients; Looking after Yourself; Questions & Answers; How to Support Others Through Grief & Loss. Volunteers have also independently attended training provided by HACC, including O H & S Risk Management for Volunteers.
- Our number of volunteers has steadily increased throughout 2009.
- Volunteers have continued to assist with transport and activities on our regular monthly client days, as well as providing one on one support.
- Volunteers were given special lunches during National Volunteer Week in May, and also in November.

CLIENTS/CARERS

- MSSS provides service to 92 clients and carers. We continue to receive referrals for clients from ACAT, Community Nursing, local hospitals, other community services, word of mouth, and from our advertising and promotions.
- Our monthly client group days continue to be popular. This year, the activities have included Indoor Games Day, Fish & Chips at Terrigal Surf Club, Travelogue Day with presentations from students from the local TAFE, Boat Cruise, Fish & Chips at Gosford Waterfront, Karaoke Day, also guest speakers including MAP worker, Centrelink, and COTA speaker on safe use of medicines.
- Nationalities represented within our Client/Carer service include Chinese, Polish, Maltese, Singaporean, Filipino, Spanish, Greek, Italian, Austrian, German, Croatian, Finnish, Hungarian, Serbian, Dutch, Russian, Fijian, Egyptian, Chilean, Vietnamese, Slovakian, Uruguayan, and Iranian.



PROMOTION

During 2008 – 2009, MSSS was involved in various activities which allowed for promotion of the service. These are listed below:

* Official Opening of the NSS Central Coast office and amalgamation of Multicultural Social Support Project, Multicultural Family Support Project, Settlement Support Project, and Thai Family Welfare Project.

- * Central Coast TAFE – Welfare
- * Gosford City Refugee Welcome Zone
- * CC Community Forum
- * Multicultural Expo
- * Manager of Volunteers Forums

- * Ourimbah University
- * Volunteer Expo
- * Mental Health Week Forum
- * CC Community Forum
- * CC Ageing & Disability Association

We have continued to advertise: in the local media; The Senior newspaper; Community Newsletters; at Neighbourhood Centres, etc, by continuous distribution of service brochures, and by networking with other community services.



Settlement Grants Program Central Coast Danielle Habib

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

This project is a new addition to the plethora of projects auspiced by Northern Settlement Services since December 2008. This project provides information, referral and support to highly disadvantaged newly arrived migrants and refugees within their first five years of settlement, and also community development.

There are 95 different nationalities living on the Central Coast with no particular dominant group however, the Filipino community are recognised as the fastest growing community. The Central Coast is seeing a steady increase in migrants arriving from Thailand, China, India and South America, predominately in the Wyong Shire. The majority of these arrivals are entering Australia on spouse visas. Within the last six months the service has witnessed a slowly increasing number of refugee families settling on the Central Coast from Somalia, Burma, Afghanistan and Sudan.

Table 1: Client Work

Case Work Issues	Contacts
Language	227
Employment	196
Volunteering	151
Education/ Training	131
Isolation	107
Financial	101
Family & Relationships/ Family Violence	88
Immigration	67
Legal	57
Cross Cultural Issues	48
Health	39
Driving License	36
Youth	35
Accommodation	29
Mental Health	19
Translation	2
Total	1333

Community Capacity Building

The Central Coast has seen a significant rise in the migrant population over the last two years. The CALD population has increased from 4% of the total population in 2006 to currently 12%. This rise has brought about issues of racism.

- The project has been successful in working in partnership with the Central Coast African Community in gaining funds from DIAC (\$5000) through the grant process to present the African Education in Schools Program to combat racism in schools. This program has been taught to approximately 890 students and the feedback received from school principals and teachers was a resounding success.

- The project has also set up an English class (English Circle) run by volunteer ESL teachers to aid isolated migrants and refugees and offers an unstructured environment to practice their language skills while forming friendships and learning about local services available to them.
- Due to the high levels of Family Violence the project has set up a CALD Family Violence Steering Committee that looks at the issues of the target group and forms strategies to best support migrant women and refugees while also working on preventative strategies. This committee has been successful in gaining funds (\$2800) from the Central Coast Domestic Violence Committee to update CALD specific resources.
- The CALD Family Violence Committee has also set up a weekly support group for the Women suffering from family violence and has also secured funds to have child care available while the women attend the group.
- The success of these groups has resulted in the worker, Danielle Habib, being approached by Northern Women's Health Centre to become a member of its Board of directors and also to be chairman of the Central Coast Domestic Violence Committee.

Networking and Integration Services

The project has been busy convening the Central Coast Multicultural Interagency (CCMI) (4 meetings).

- The CCMI was responsible for the most successful Multicultural Expo held to date. This expo had over 300 attendees with 38 varying service providers.
- Issues raised at the CCMI included: lack of use of interpreters, need for Thai translation of RTA handbook, services' lack of knowledge of T.I.S client code, services' need for cross cultural training, increasing numbers of woman suffering from family violence, and the need for an updated list of bi-lingual doctors on the Central Coast.
- The Interagency has been commended on its work from Labour MP Belinda Neal with a request to attend a meeting.
- Official meeting with the Gosford Mayor was coordinated which included 18 ethno-specific community leaders who spoke in their mother tongue. The aim of this meeting was to raise the profile of the migrant population on the Central Coast while forming partnerships between the groups and Council. One benefit of this meeting was the approval of \$15000 from Gosford Council to fund the next Harmony Day in 2010.
- Coordination of CC African Community, Australian Filipino Association and the Ugnay Kabayan to work with seven other ethno-specific groups to present Harmony Day activities and cultural exchanges to 750 people.
- The project draws on the strengths gained from close working relationships with Centrelink, Gosford and Wyong Council, TAFE AMEP Program, CC Disability Network, Multicultural Social Support Service, Dept of Education and Training, CC Domestic Violence Committee, Northern Women's Health Centre and 18 ethno specific groups to improve services and look at designing strategies to best support clients.

Training

DIAC Regional & Rural Training NSW, Domestic Violence in CALD communities.

This past six months has been positively eventful and has only been possible with the strong support received by staff and management of Northern Settlement Services.



Multicultural Family Support Project Central Coast

Pari Batha

Funded by Department of Community Services

This project provides support to people from culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) backgrounds who live on the Central Coast (CC). In particular the worker assists families with young children, adolescents and their families and women who can be suffering from various disadvantage, hardship, isolation and misfortune. Furthermore, the project assists the general community, government and non government organisations and, ethnic groups and communities by providing information, referral, support and case work on a case by case basis. In addition, the worker:

- Provides advocacy for and access to relevant services;
- Provides information and education to raise awareness of CALD issues, through cultural training sessions and workshops;
- Successfully builds and maintains a number of community networks while at the same time assisting newly formed and long term ongoing ethnic (support) groups;
- Forms relationships and contacts within and provides assistance to the leaders of different religious groups and organisations.

The project officer is available at NSS Central Coast office 3 days per week and at Outreach on the fourth. This report covers the work of the project from January 2009 to June 2009.

Issues/Problems Presented by Clients:

Problem/issues	Face to Face	Telephone
Immigration	14	23
Income support	17	39
Education	16	15
Mental Health	12	25
Housing	12	16
Legal	17	47
Employment	9	13
Domestic Violence	9	16
Referring clients to Ethnic Groups	17	41
Total	124	235

Most clients are unaware of services and the support system in our area, they are often isolated and without family or friends on the Central Coast. Often they are unable to speak English at all or are not fluent in the language and thus unable to communicate effectively.

Community Development:

- A questionnaire was developed and we consulted with 140 members of the community including but not limited to members of Italian Groups, CALD students from Wyong and Gosford TAFE and members of the CALD community.
- Consultations with existing ethnic groups including the South American, Italian, Iranian and Indian groups etc.
- Contacts with Religious Leaders eg Baha'i, Buddhists, Hindus, Jewish, and Muslim.
- Cultural training was provided for Coast Shelter.

- The Central Coast Multicultural Support Group was established. This Group will act as a steering Committee to support the project. At present the group has seven members from CALD backgrounds.
- Assistance was provided to a number of different ethnic and cultural groups. Consequently, the project was able to secure two free venues for the Latino and Friends group, one in San Remo Neighbourhood Centre (Wyong area) and other at Green Point Community Centre (Gosford Area).
- Assistance was given to CC Iranian Community, a Hungarian group with their venue issues, and the new Indian group (EKTA MANDI INC) with their public liability insurance, venue acquisition and support letters for Wyong Council.
- I am developing a service directory comprising multicultural services on the Central Coast.
- Together with Gosford Council's Community workers, we organised the launch of Gosford City Council's Refugee Welcome Zone .

Other roles and support provided

- Management Committee of the Central Coast DV Court Advocacy Service
- DoCS Hunter Central Coast Advisory group
- Central Coast Multicultural Interagency
- CALD DV group
- Families First CALD Family and Children Group Steering Committee
- CALD Youth Learning Centre
- Community Leadership Project Steering Committee
- CLSD legal forum

Film Global Project

This Project in partnership with Gosford City Council Youth Services facilitated a series of intergenerational multicultural film nights. The aim was to promote harmony, diversity, inclusiveness, and the strengthening of community. The film nights have been held monthly with the assistance of the different ethnic groups from whose communities the film is presented. These groups provide food from their country of origin and also promote awareness in the area of cultural arts. They often provide performers including singers and dancer as well of course as the film (with English subtitles) that celebrates their cultural heritage with people from their country and the wider Central Coast community. These events are usually attended by between 80 to 150 members of the local community

Final word

I am enjoying working with the NSS Management and my colleagues to provide autonomous and effective services for members of our community who require it. I would particularly like to acknowledge my colleagues at the Central Coast Office for the collegiality they provide.



AFRICAN TEAM

Ms Kiri Hata
Complex Case Support Coordinator
Safe Arrival, Safe Families Project
African Team Leader

Ms Flora Aine
African Support Project

Mr Mohamed Kamara
African Youth Project

Ms Helen Buchanan
African Parenting Groups Project

Ms Joselyne Ntahomvukiye
African Family Welfare Project

Amer Manyon
African Parenting Assistant
(Summarised in Team Leader report)

Mr Alhousseynou Ly
Mauritanian Welfare Support Project
(Summarised in Team Leader report)

Mr Michael Freund
Volunteers Coordinator



African Team Leader
Kiri Hata

Overview

With a client group drawn from a number of African refugee communities in Newcastle and the Hunter, our capacity and reach has grown during the year. The African Team has supported highly disadvantaged recently arrived refugees from Burundi, Democratic Republic of Congo, Liberia, Mauritania, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Sudan. The major issues faced by these individuals were grouped around accommodation, family relationships, education and employment, settlement issues, legal and financial issues and general welfare support.

While the workload remained high, we have also seen a turnover of staff, with the departure of Simon Pabek and Marial Fieg, and arrival of Flora Aine (Sudanese and African Support Worker) and Alhousseynou Ly (Mauritanian Support Worker). Mohamed Kamara moved into the African Youth Project, while Amer Manyon (Sudanese), Joselyne Ntahomvukiye (Burundian) and Zenaida Edmunds (African) provided specific and general community family support. Helen Buchanan improved and expanded the group work programs through Penola House and has successfully increased our reach to both men and women. The volunteer program was reviewed and improved by Michael Freund, and resulted in greater numbers of active volunteers and stronger support for both the homework centre and group work.

There have been new arrivals from the Congo during the last 12 months, and we have been informed as a region that new groups are expected early in the next financial year. A key success of the team during the period has been the greater networking and upgrading of skills and procedures of individual staff to enable them to more successfully complete the deliver of their important roles.

Funding for the programs under the African Team banner has come from Department of Immigration and Citizenship (DIAC - Settlement Grants Program), Department of Families and Housing, Community Services and Indigenous Affairs (FAHCSIA - Stronger Family and Community Strategy), Department of Community Services (DoCS - Families First), NSW Clubs (CDSE) and Northern Settlement Services core funding.

As Team Leader, it has been my pleasure since November, 2008 to provide support and leadership to a growing team of committed and capable co-workers. I recognise that we build on the strengths and successes provided by those who came before us, and I trust that we will continue to meet the needs of all refugee arrivals to Newcastle and the Hunter.



Safe Arrival, Safe Families Project

Kiri Hata (Team Leader)

Funded by Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs

-through the *Stronger Families & Communities Strategies* program

The project began in September 2007 and finished June 30, 2009. The objective of the project was to improve family relationships within refugee families, through a number of activities. These included culturally appropriate parenting information and referral sessions for recent arrivals; training programs for community leaders and workers to improve their capacity to assist their communities; and mentoring and support for refugee youths to remain engaged within their families and improve relationships.

Amer Manyon (Sudan), Joselyne Ntahomvukiye (Burundi) and Alhousseynou Ly (Mauritania) were employed part time to support their respective communities' women's and men's groups meeting at Penola House. Helen Buchanan consulted widely to draw up the programs delivered during the year. This formal program of support has been useful in strengthening parenting and relationship skills, in partnership with other agencies and individuals, including Newcastle Family Support, Relationships Australia, TAFE, Hunter Area Health Services, Refugee Health Services, local Pharmacy services, NSW Police, Tenancy Advisory and Advocacy Service, Centrelink, DoCS, Nutritionist Sylvia Ruano, Legal Aid and the daily support of NSS volunteers.

Casework

The role of African Team Leader also requires a level of support to all programs and individual requests for assistance on a daily basis.

The major issues with which I have dealt include housing, legal and financial issues, education and training, employment and family matters.

I supported over 450 clients who attended our offices for assistance, and responded to more than 700 telephone requests. I also presented 6 sessions to groups and attended 15 interagency meetings.

Conclusion

I have greatly enjoyed my time with Northern Settlement Services and consider it a privilege to work with such talented and committed individuals. I believe this organisation, its management and staff, are well placed to continue to provide high quality and appropriate services to clients who have already faced much in their lives and find comfort and support in working with us towards a better life in Australia.



Supporting Staff pictured above: (L-R)

Amer Manyon, Joselyne Ntahomvukiye, Alhousseynou Ly, Helen Buchanan



African Welfare Project

Flora Aine

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

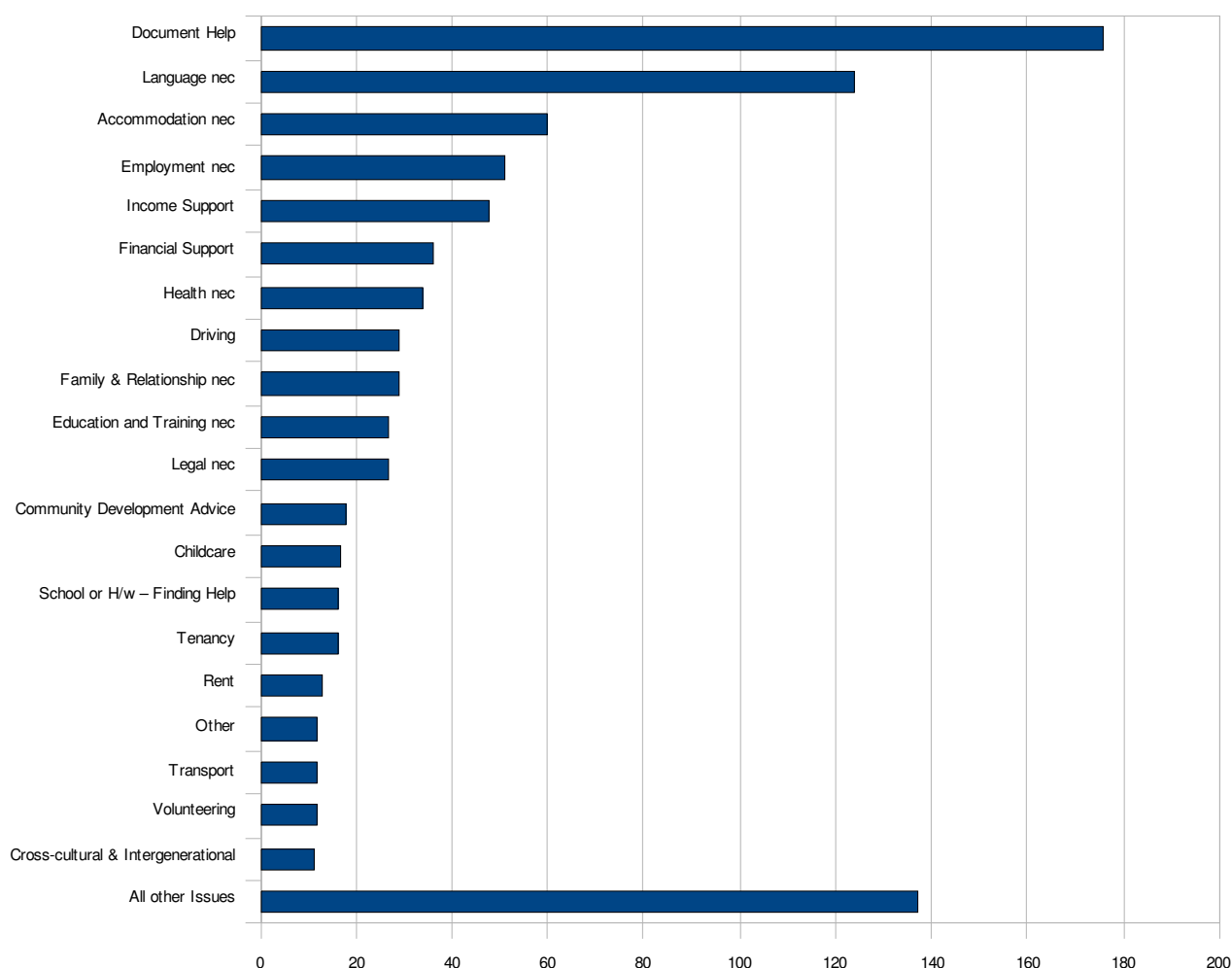
This project provides information referral and casework services to disadvantage African refugees and migrants in the Newcastle, Maitland and Lake Macquarie regions. It is funded by the Department of Immigration & Citizenship under the Settlement Grants Program (SGP).

Casework and Referrals

During the funding period, the project assisted 329 individuals of the target group, through one-on-one casework. All 329 were also referred to other service providers for additional support. A total of 1742 formal and informal referrals were made by the program to various mainstream service providers based on the needs of the clients.

The tables below show statistics of Client Issues Addressed and Client Nationalities.

Table 1: Client Issues Addressed



In **Table 1**, (previous page), the two most significant client issues were Documents (176) and Language (124), followed by Accommodation (60), Employment (51), Income (48) and Financial (36).

Table 2: Client Nationalities

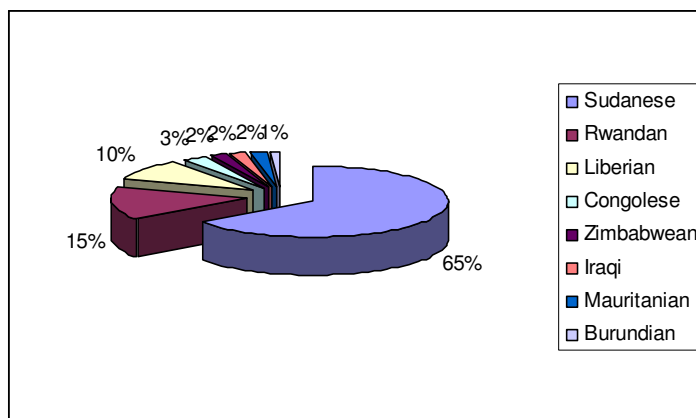


Table 2 shows that the vast majority of clients were from Sudanese backgrounds with people from Rwanda and Liberia forming the next 2 largest client groups. Most clients lived in the Newcastle area with the others living in Maitland and Lake Macquarie.

Training and Group Sessions

The program also provided 59 training and group sessions to the client group, with the aim of assisting them to become self-reliant, through gaining an understanding of the Australian values and social and legal practices. The topics covered included: accommodation and housing, health, Centrelink assistance, education and training, settlement information, community development, law, domestic violence, consumer rights, tenant rights, parenting, and advocacy.

Social Integration

The program also assisted the client group with integration into the broader community, by organising their participation in local activities and events, such as: Refugee Day, Young Mothers, and International Women's Day.

I also assisted the NSS Volunteers Coordinator on many occasions to contact clients and assisting at client-volunteer meetings.

Meetings Attended

During the funding period, I attended a number of meetings as a part of the ongoing consultation and networking of the program with other services providers. These meetings included: NSS case workers, multicultural refugees inter-agency, Newcastle Forum, Jesmond Neighbourhood Centre, TAFE, Maitland Neighbourhood Centre, Maitland Council social planning, and Global Connection.

Conclusion

I am very grateful to be a member of the NSS African Team this year and have enjoyed working with them to help achieve the objectives of our program. I am very thankful to the team members for their cooperative spirit, and am especially grateful for the guidance and help of my Team Leader Kiri Hata, and also colleague Alex Burns.



African Youth Project

Mohamed Kamara

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- under the Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

The aim of the project is to identify and address the issues of young people of African refugee background aged from 12-24 years, living in Newcastle with outreach to Lake Macquarie and Maitland. The position aims to increase youth participation in existing services and to develop responses to cover gaps in youth services provision, especially in small and emerging communities.

The main work of the project is to provide support, information, referral, casework, service planning, and development & capacity building to assist African young people in their settlement. The project also participates in local and regional youth and community networks.

During the funding period:

- The project assisted 123 individuals of the client target group.
- A total of 524 formal and informal clients contact were made by the program.
- A total of 177 formal and informal clients referrals were made by the program to various mainstream service providers base on the needs of clients.

Table 1: African Youth Project Clients by Community

Sudanese	50%
Liberian	23%
Sierra Leone	5%
Burundian	7%
Congolese	6%
Mauritanian	9%

Table 1 indicates the country of origin of young people that the project has worked with from all African communities in the Newcastle, Lake Macquarie and Maitland areas. Sudanese young people were the largest group at 50% of all clients. This number was below last year's 65% figure, mainly because of the success of NSS youth programs, as well as some client relocation away from the area. The good relationship this project has with schools and community services provides relatively easy access to the client group.

The newest refugee community of Mauritanian youth has participated well in NSS and local services, such as our homework centres and community sporting activities.

Education & Training

Large numbers of young Africans are enrolled in various primary and secondary schools and TAFEs around Newcastle, Lake Macquarie and Maitland areas. Since its inception the project has been working with schools and parents for the purpose of integrating the newly arrived young people into school-life, as well as into the mainstream community. I have attended regular meetings in schools with staff and parents, and ran sessions about cultural awareness and study/employment pathway options.

The project has outreached to schools with large numbers of African students for one half day per week, eg. San Clemente High (Mayfield), Waratah Technology Campus, Lambton High. These visits aim to mentor and build confidence and self esteem in African students, and to break down communication barriers between these students, their parents and school staff. The sessions have also provided opportunities for African students to meet with Police to discuss their concerns.

Youth Employment

Unemployment is a huge issue for all African communities and especially for young African people in the local region, resulting in social and economic disadvantage. This project is working hard with the other African projects at NSS to raise awareness and knowledge of employment, vocational and educational needs of refugee African young people, hosting many sessions in different areas, eg. schools, TAFE, Work Directions/Job Find, Salvation Army and utilising various networks.

Recreational Activities

I have developed and supported a range of sporting and recreational activities for young Africans during 2008-2009, which have been a great way of encouraging young people to participate in community activities, assisting with their integration into Australian life, improving self-confidence and developing life skills.

These include:

- Weekly activities at Newcastle Police & Citizen's Youth Club (PCYC), eg. gymnasium, boxing, weightlifting, etc and also the PCYC basketball team.
- Weekly games at Newcastle Basketball Association for African Lions team.
- Weekly activities at Hamilton South Community Centre (run by Samaritans Foundation), eg. social activities, table-tennis, pool table, video games, etc.
- African soccer teams (Flying Eagles and African Lions) participating in friendly matches against mainstream teams at the TAFE ground.
- Several camping excursions in partnership with STARTTS Recreation Officer.
- Weekly Youth dancing groups: West African, Sudanese and Burundi.
- Youth mentoring program at Waratah High School in partnership with STARTTS.

Skill Development

I am finishing my second year in B. Social Science at the University of Newcastle. I attended the two day DIAC SGP & CSSS workers rural conference in March 2009, which provided training for working in regional and rural NSW.

Conclusion

This project has been able to support young African refugees in a range of activities, as well as focus on and support other agencies in the direct need of African young people. It has also assisted with the development of strategies to support African youths and to encourage these youths to have self esteem and support themselves.



African Parenting Groups Project

Helen Buchanan

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

-under the Settlement Grants Program (SGP) &

Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs

The NSS African Parenting Group work project, funded by DIAC and FAHCSIA, was developed to meet the needs of some of the most disadvantaged groups in Australia – those who have arrived as refugees and require substantial support to enable them to take advantage of life in Australia.

Designed to improve the parenting skills of African families, the programs also encourage independent thinking and problem solving for families, community development, and allow individuals and families to develop new skills and address cross cultural issues.

Some of the major issues faced by these groups include housing and tenancy issues, support negotiating access to better services and benefits, legal and court support, nutrition and health information, education and employment opportunities.

The groups include:

1. African men's group
2. African men's fund raising BBQ
3. African men's workshop
4. Burundi women's parenting group
5. Sudanese women's parenting group
6. Equatorian women's parenting group
7. Mauritanian women's parenting group
8. Young women's parenting group
9. Female youth groups/activities
10. Male youth groups/activities

Topics covered under the parenting and life skills program groups are in segments related to direct child rearing practices, the law, education, health, nutrition and social/relaxation skills, including arts & crafts.

The African men's workshop, in particular, has been very successful in attracting and holding the interest and support of the client group. They have raised funds from their regular bbq at Penola House every Tuesday and Thursday, which have enabled them to buy tools and equipment for their programs. Penola House has also benefited from the new skills, with the addition of access ramps, safety latches and gates, blackboards for the children, painting, network cabling and repair of furniture. Management of the barbeque has also seen an improvement in safe food handling knowledge and skills, ordering of supplies and managing money.

There were also several camps held during the year, which attracted eager young African men and women to try their hand at adventure and activities which were new to them. The opportunity was also taken to introduce them to concepts of safe health practices and negotiating personal safety. Other services including STARTTS, Hunter Area Health and NSW Police attended to present messages and programs.

As required, individual support and advice was offered to clients during all of these programs.



African Family Welfare Project

Joselyne Ntahomvukiye

Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs

The case load for the year included 18 refugee families (69 people) from the Burundian, Congolese and Rwandan Communities. The main activities and support offered for these clients were aimed at enhancing those approaches geared towards family support, education, integration, health and skills development both inside and outside of the home environments. These approaches drew upon and further built social capital, self-reliance and empowerment of these central African communities, assisting smoother transition into successful settling, thus reducing their dependency and increasing their positive involvement in society.

Table 1 shows the list of issues that were presented by the clients for assistance by this project, during the reporting period.

Table 1: Issues Presented and Client Instances

Issues presented	Face to Face	Telephone
Immigration and proposing relatives	35	19
Employment issues	86	60
Education and training issues	58	113
Learning English	86	15
Housing and accommodation	150	202
Health issues	80	86
Mental health	27	38
Childcare	41	26
Youth issues	40	13
Parenting issues	117	38
Legal issues	35	12
Police	10	8
Translation of document	3	0
Transport issues	109	16
Assistance with forms	134	35
Culture information	13	17
Dealing with friends	237	277
Language problem	366	134
Needs of interpreter	396	273
Budgeting	60	20
Bills issues	38	44
Separation issues	5	5
Pass Port	9	8
Banks	37	10
Reading a letter	144	22
Total	2305	1491

The project provided support for a wide range of activities, including:

Activities / Information Sessions:

Organised activities & information sessions for the men, women and children continued to improve their understanding of parenting, healthy living and integration into the wider community. Penola House in Hamilton was the venue for many of these sessions, including:

- Women's Health sessions - monthly, eg. mental health, prescription medicines, etc.
- Parenting training - 6 weeks.
- Various information sessions, eg. Australian education system; nutrition & healthy food; police & law; Centrelink.
- Sewing classes with volunteers – weekly.
- Men's BBQ and handyman skills group with volunteers – twice per week.
- Men's football (soccer) – 3 times per week.
- NSS Homework Centres: Hamilton PS, San Clemente HS Mayfield, Waratah Technology Campus. Volunteer tutors assist children with homework, reading, etc.
- NAALA Saturday English classes in Merewether stopped in November 2008.

General Home & Family Support:

Home visits were frequently made to young parents and families with children, to provide support with issues such as: childcare, GP and hospital appointments, accommodation, banks, interpreting and filing in forms.

Accommodation:

Rental accommodation in particular remained a major issue. Finding suitable housing for our clients, especially those with large families, in the Newcastle area was a real challenge.

Employment:

Employment opportunities in Newcastle were extremely limited. About 9 people found work picking grapes in the Hunter Vineyards (Feb. only). About 12 people were actively looking for employment in the Newcastle area for the year. One family relocated to Adelaide to find work.

Transport:

Transport has been another significant issue for many families. The number of hours (120) required to apply for the 'P' driving test, has made it very difficult for drivers to gain their licence. Some people are receiving volunteer assistance with driving supervision.

I would like to thank the Board, Violetta & my colleagues at NSS for their support & encouragement throughout the year.



Volunteers Coordinator

Michael Freund

Funded by Northern Settlement Service Ltd

The purpose of this part-time position (3.5 days/week), funded by NSS, is to recruit, register and co-ordinate the activities of volunteers who work with refugee families. The position is attached to the African Team, as our African refugee clients generate the majority of requests for volunteers. This year's activities can be summarised as follows:

Recruitment:

Continual recruitment of new volunteers was again critical to the success of our volunteer programs - to replace withdrawn volunteers, and also to staff expanded programs, such as the Homework Centre. Recruitment was aided by promoting our specific volunteering needs with the following services: University of Newcastle Careers Service and School of Education; Hunter Volunteer Centre; NSS Volunteers website and mailing list.

Registration:

Each new volunteer was given an induction to volunteering with NSS, including information about our volunteering programs & policies, and background & cultural information on our refugee clients. New volunteers registered by filling out/signing these forms: 1) Volunteer Agreement; 2) Volunteer Information; 3) Prohibited Persons Employment Declaration; 4) Police Check. From the start of 2009, all new volunteers underwent an online National Criminal History Record Check. This has resulted in a vast improvement in efficiency, cost, time turnaround, and national coverage, from the method used previously. A photo was also taken of each new volunteer, and used by reception staff to make the ID badge.

As at 30 June 2009, a total of 200 registered volunteers were actively working in client programs, or awaiting placement. In the reporting period, the following statistics occurred:

Table 1: Statistics

Volunteer Category	Vols.	% change from 2007-08
Enquiries received	250	+61%
Signed up	149	+35%
Placed with Client	162	+69%
Re-started or Extended	32	+60%
Became Inactive	101	+261% *
Withdrawn	76	+375% *

Table 1 (left): The large increases in volunteer numbers were partly due to an additional day being allocated to this role. A comprehensive audit of our database was also conducted, resulting in much improved data accuracy. This accounts for the huge Inactive & Withdrawn percentages.*

Programs / Activities:

The table below shows the main volunteer programs/activities during the reporting period, and the number of volunteers who have participated in each program:

Program	Vols.	Volunteer Activities
Homework Centre (HWC)	65	Volunteers assisted school students with homework, reading, study, one afternoon per week, at the following centres: - Hamilton Public School (mainly primary, and some Yr.11-12)

Program	Vols.	Volunteer Activities
Homework Centre (HWC) <i>(continued)</i>		- San Clemente High School, Mayfield (Yr.7-10) - Waratah High School, Technology Campus (Yr.7-10) Each centre was managed by a co-ordinator employed by NSS. The program expanded significantly this year, courtesy of funding from CDSE (NSW Clubs) and Life Without Barriers, enabling setup of the additional centres at Mayfield & Waratah.
In-Home Tutoring	68	Volunteers provided homework, reading, study support for students one-on-one in the family home, or local library, etc. Students ranged from primary school to TAFE & University level.
Volunteers in Schools Program (VISP)	32	Volunteers provided in-class support for students, one-on-one at a range of primary & secondary public schools. DET Refugee Support Officer, Renata Ninevski, ran VISP training sessions for the volunteers, and also facilitated their school placements.
Penola House	57	Volunteers at Penola House assisted men, women, child clients in a broad range of activities, including: sewing, childminding, office/reception, house searching, gardening, and various other special projects. A particular success was the men's group for BBQ lunch, handyman work, etc. organised by Helen Buchanan.
Driving Supervision	19	Volunteers supervised learner drivers, assisting them to log the 120 hours necessary to apply for their 'P' licence. It continued to be very difficult to find volunteers willing to do driving supervision, hence the client waiting list progressed very slowly.
General Home / Family / Transport	27	Volunteers provided support in some client family homes with issues such as: homecare, assistance with babies & children, socialisation, bill-paying, help with government services, and more. Volunteers also provided a range of transport services, eg. shopping, sporting, medical/dental/legal appointments. Note: Client demand for these services was very low.
Adult English Literacy	10	Volunteers provided English language support for adults, one-on-one in the family home, or local library, or at NSS, etc. Note: Client demand for these services was very low.
Miscellaneous	20	Volunteers assisted with several one-off projects, such as: school holiday camps, youth activity days, etc.

Other Activities:

Helen Buchanan presented two OH&S sessions on Infectious Diseases, Home Visits & Reporting Incidents. Over 20 volunteers attended and the feedback was very positive.

The FACHSIA Department provided NSS with a grant for volunteering items and activities. Items purchased by NSS included: marquee, first aid kit, and digital camera. The funding also covered reimbursement of fuel costs, and about 20 volunteers benefitted from this.

We also continued our collaboration with the Community Refugee Support (CRS) Group, supporting their various social and awareness raising activities.

Acknowledgements:

A huge thank-you goes to all of our wonderful volunteers, without whom none of these support programs are possible. In December, NSS recognised the dedication of approx. 150 volunteers, by sending each person a gift and laminated certificate. A special note of appreciation goes to our homework centre co-ordinators, Lauren Miles & Georgina Ramsay, whose commitment has made this growing project such a success. Thanks also to Ron Davis (CRS co-ordinator) for his continued support of refugee welfare. Finally, thanks for the support of all African Team workers, NSS office staff & management. I look forward to working with such great people next year, in supporting our refugee clients.



WELFARE TEAM

Ms Petrona Kelly
Welfare Team Leader
Filipino Social Worker
Brighter Futures Program

Ms Elena Ferguson
Russian Welfare Project

Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Strong Women, Stronger Communities Project
(Domestic Violence Education & Support)
Thai Welfare Project

Ms Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Project
(Samoan)

Ms Lydia Manusiu
Pacific Islander Welfare Project
(Tongan)

Ms Zenaida Edmunds
Migrant & Refugee Women's Support Project

Ms Miza Torlakovic
Multicultural Family Support Project (Families First)



Filipino Welfare Project

Petrona Kelly

Funded by Department of Community Services

This project provides support services to highly disadvantaged Filipino people, mainly women and children who are experiencing physical and psychological crisis and hardship through domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and isolation, immigration issues and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

The worker is available at NSS four days during the week.

This report covers the period 1st July 2008 to June 2009.

This year I have provided approximately 1392 instances of services to clients. Their issues are inter-related in many cases and on many occasions, a client presented a number of needs and problems. As can be seen from the statistics, client settlement information forms a significant part of my work; domestic violence, immigration, housing and accommodation, financial, family problem, and legal matters predominate as problem areas.

Table 1: Issues/Problems Presented by Clients

Issues/Problems	Face To Face	Phone	Issues/ Problems	Face To Face	Phone
Immigration & Citizenship	110	86	Mental Health	43	51
Income Support & Finances	90	58	Childcare	35	26
Employment	50	38	Aged Care	39	20
Education & Training	60	44	Youth Issues	68	54
Overseas Qualifications	38	24	Legal Matters	88	56
Learning English	19	31	Police	15	21
Housing & Accommodation	98	65	Family Problem	89	80
Health	45	52	Settlement Information	240	237
Domestic Violence	115	104	Other	150	245
Total (Face to Face)	1 392		Total (Telephone)		1 292

Other issues include: social/emotional, separation and divorce, material assistance, death and bereavement, funeral service arrangement, harassment and discrimination, compensation, access to belongings, neighbourhood disputes, conflict with landlords, problems with real estate agents, travel infringements, passport renewals, lost passports, lost citizenship certificates, dual citizenship, language difficulties, transport problems, birthday/special occasion celebrations, JP signatures, supporting letters, court support, social isolation, cultural information, etc.

Table 2: Services Provided

Services	Instances	Services	Instances
Counselling	66	Visits: Hospital/Home/Agency	58
Advocacy	45	Form filling	167
Consultation (to & from)	30	Document Translations	156
Referrals made	277	Interpreting	126
JP Signatures	150	Transport assistance	15
Letters of Support	22	General Information	240
Court Support	40	Total	1392

Networking & Training:

During the year, I maintained networking with peers and colleagues and other service providers to further develop skills and enhance information level to better serve the needs of the Filipino community by attending the following trainings, meetings, seminars, etc: NSS Caseworkers, Team Leaders, NSS Staff meetings, NSS Planning Day and NSS AGM, Centrelink Multicultural Forums, Co-Exist NSW, Good for Kids, Good for Life, Train the Trainer Training, Well-Being Expo, Coaching & Mentoring Training, Homelessness Interagency Network Forum, Public Interest Advocacy Training, Brighter Futures Conference, Workshop on Diversity – Developing a More Accessible Service, Family NSW Outcomes Workshop – Family Model, Occupational Health & Safety, Workshop on Suicide Prevention, White Ribbon Breakfast, Hunter Parents & Teachers Community Languages Schools Association, Smith Family's Learn to Manage Your Money, Community Agencies Information Forum (Housing Appeals Committee), EDuCARE Support Services, Parents As Teachers (PAT), etc.

Other Activities:

As the Team Leader of the NSS Welfare Team I have coordinated and organised the monthly caseworkers meetings and invited speakers from organisations such as Migration Agents Registration Authority (MARA), Leapfrog, DoCS, Compass, etc. Likewise, I have been doing Statutory Declarations (DIAC Form 1040) relating to domestic violence for clients of NSS Migration agents and co-workers whose clients are in domestic violence situations and who are on spouse visa (temporary) (They are accessing the government's policy on domestic policy regulations). As an accredited member of the Australian Association of Social Workers (AASW) and considered a competent person, I am qualified to provide professional opinion on whether a person has experienced domestic violence. The Department (DIAC) will decide on their future & their permanent residency in Australia.

I have the responsibility of completing the annual NSS Service Specification and Achievement Performance Reports for DoCS funded projects here at NSS such as Russian, Thai, Tongan, Samoan, CALD Families First and Filipino Welfare Projects.

I also spent time coordinating the Filipino Choir of Newcastle in their rehearsals and performances.

Once again, I had a busy, but satisfying year. I would like to thank my colleagues for their continued support and encouragement. Likewise, warm thanks go to the NSS Board of Management for their unending support to the Filipino Welfare Project.



Brighter Futures Program

Petrona Kelly

Funded by the Department of Community Services
- through the Early Intervention Program

The Brighter Futures Program is an initiative of the NSW Department of Community Services through its Early Intervention Program to provide targeted support to vulnerable families, to support them in caring for their children.

The key aims of the program are to:

- Promote healthy development of children
- Develop strong, functional and well supported families, and
- Reduce and prevent child abuse and neglect in participating families.

The program provides a wide range of flexible services and supports that caters for individuals as well as family needs to improve emotional, social, health and educational developmental outcomes for families and their children.

The service components required can be sorted into the following categories:

- Key co-ordination functions (case management, etc.)
- Home visiting
- Quality childcare
- Parenting programs

The target group for the Brighter Futures (BF) program is families who are expecting a child or have children up to 8 years of age. It is anticipated in future years that families with children up to 14 years will be included in the program.

Families must also present with at least one vulnerability - that if not addressed, is likely to escalate and impact adversely on the capacity of the parent to provide care adequately and therefore on the well being of child/children. Vulnerabilities such as domestic violence, parental drug and alcohol abuse, parental mental health issues, a lack of extended family or social supports, parents with significant learning difficulties or and intellectual disability, and/or child behaviour management problems like parent/child conflict, school problems.

To deliver such a program in Newcastle and Lake Macquarie areas are the Samaritans Foundation and Wandiyali ATSI as the Lead Agency in collaboration with government and non-government agencies.

Northern Settlement Services (NSS) delivers the program to CALD families who are willing to participate in the program through home visiting. The role of BF home visitor is to build skills and capacity of the family including building a positive relationship with the parents, referring clients to external services (in consultation with case manager), ensuring the well being of children, providing parental support, advocating for clients e.g. for housing/Centrelink, writing letters of support, supporting court attendance, attending case meetings with case managers, teaching/mentoring living/housekeeping skills/life skills, providing general support, etc.

Working on the goals outlined in the case plans, this year, I had the task to home visit four families with 14 children altogether with complex issues and needs. However, two of the families have now exited the program; one relocated to Sydney and the other was able to find a job by doing further training.

Other activities are the monthly meetings with other BF workers from various agencies and the annual conference. There was also the 5 – days PAT (Parents as Teachers) Training last May, which I attended during my annual leave. The Parents as Teachers is an early childhood parent education and family support program serving families from pregnancy until their child enters kindergarten. It provides information, support and encouragement parents need to help their children develop during the crucial early years of life.

There is great value & benefit for clients & the agency through the work of this project & I would like to thank the Board & Staff for their support of the program.



Russian Welfare Project

Elena Ferguson

Funded by Department of Community Services

The Russian Family Welfare project is funded by Department of Community services and by the NSW Department of Community Services.

This project provides support services to highly disadvantaged Russian speaking people, mainly women and children who are experiencing immigration issues, social isolation, language problems, difficulties in finding a job and therefore stress and frustration which creates barriers in adjusting to this new country.

This report covers the period from 01.07.08 to 30.06.09; during this time the Russian Welfare Project had approximately between 21 occasions of service per month including multiple issues, total 135 cases; and each case had between five and eight separate issues to deal with; anticipated 15 clients per month, face to face and over the phone.

The Russian welfare worker is available at NSS for one day each week.

The position requires development of information packages for the new arrivals in Australia and their supporters. This information includes: how to access local events, aged services, the NSS's immigration service, health information, education (TAFE), translation as well as services that are available from Centrelink.

Table 1: Client Issues

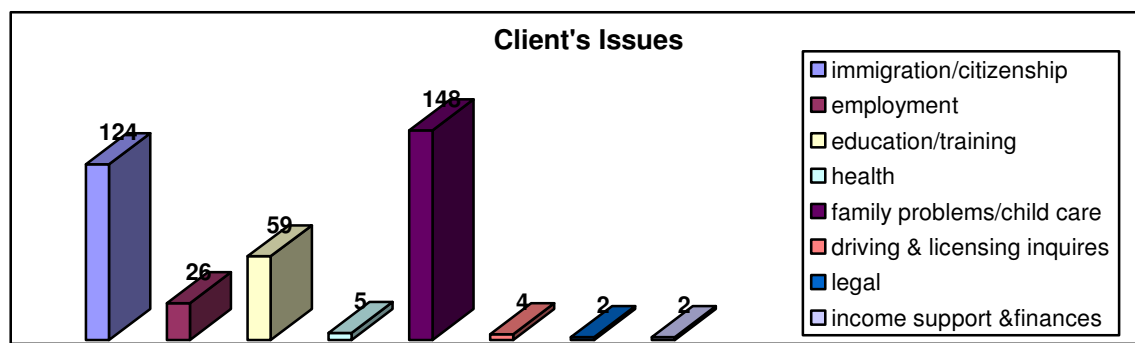


Table 1 (above) illustrates a predominance of clients seeking help with family and child support problems (**148**), which result in a lack of family support due to the distance from their motherland and a cultural difference within the Russian-Australian family.

Another area, where support was needed was Immigration/Citizenship (**124**); also, education/training English/overseas qualification issues (**59**) also required assistance; in addition, employment (**26**), health (**5**), driving test (**4**), legal advice (**2**) and income support/finances (**2**) problems were presented during the year.

To provide community education to raise awareness of health issues two information sessions were organised during the year: Depression and Men's health with partnership Hunter New England Health; in providing vocation support activities Cooking Classes and Russian languages classes were held during the year (minimum of 13 people attend each session).

Russian language Newsletter "Berezka" were issued 6 times a year to the 100 families each time with information about Community meetings, gatherings, announcements, about welfare services availability, and other Cultural and linguistically materials were included. Also, brochures on Russian language were sent to Russian Families on issues such as: Domestic Violence, Women Health, Citizenship and Centrelink providing settlement information for new arrivals.

The role of community building was supported through cultural events, celebrations and social gatherings (8) such as: Family's parties with performances, concerts, cultural games and dances; Russian New Year party; Russian Christmas party for children; International Women's Day celebration; Day of Victory (War II), and family Picnic, with average 47 people attended each activity. One of joint activity, such as Australian Day Celebration, was undertaken as a partnership with The City of Newcastle, where NSS's Russian worker and the Russian group have represented the Russian Community of Newcastle with Russian stole, kiosk, costumers and art.

Networking & Meetings:

To build and maintain community service system networks, to promote best practice, improve the level of information exchange and service coordination the following meetings were attended during the year:

- Case workers meetings NSS (8)
- Staff meetings NSS (2)
- Planning Day NSS
- AGM NSS
- Centrelink Multicultural Forum (4)
- Career Information Centre
- White Ribbon Day/Violence against Women
- Migration Agents Registration Authority
- Grant & Project Management Workshop
- Working with diversity- developing a more accessible service/DOCS/ training course
- OH&S trainings (2) Home visits, Mental illness
- The Smith Family's Financial Literacy Course/ (5) sessions
- Celebrating Harmony Day
- Lower Hunter Community Forum on Health/ workshop

This project has been able to support Russian new arrivals and the community in a range of different activities, which assist them in gaining knowledge and skills to settle well into Australian society.



Thai Welfare Project

Nellie Srisurapon

Funded by Department of Community Services

This year has been a busy one for me with the Thai community in the Newcastle area and its surroundings, as well as the Central Coast increasing steadily with more people within the community being aware of our services here at NSS. Currently, there are 168 households on the NSS mailing list in the Hunter region and 62 households in the Central Coast region.

Casework kept me busy throughout the year with clients having the following:

Table 1: Issues/problems

ISSUE /PROBLEMS	FACE TO FACE	TELEPHONE
Immigration	38	103
Education & Training	12	75
Housing & Accommodation	8	83
Employment	5	19
Income	11	55
Mental Health	3	23
Domestic Violence	31	146
Legal	21	124
Police	7	61
Family Problems	12	34
Settlement Information	6	65
Health	5	42
Court assist	8	
Other	52	20
	TOTAL: 219	TOTAL: 850

Other issues include: social/emotional, language difficulties, document translations, interpreting, form filling, cultural information, separation and divorce, supporting letters, material assistance, transport problems, etc.

A TOTAL OF 1,069 INSTANCES OF SERVICE HAVE BEEN PROVIDED TO THE THAI COMMUNITY AS WELL AS OTHER SERVICE PROVIDERS.

As can be seen from Table 1 (above), the majority of issues have been immigration followed by domestic violence and legal matters. Casework for these clients can go on for months or even longer. Some of these clients are often on spouse temporary visa which requires applications to Department of Immigration & Citizenship (DIAC) accessing the department's Domestic Violence Policy for them to gain permanent residency.

Referrals of clients have been from Department of Community Services (DOCS), Domestic Violence Court Assistance Scheme (DVCAS), TAFE, Newcastle University, Family Support Services, Women's & Children's Refuges, NSS co-workers as well as self referrals and from friends and relatives and other members of the Thai community.

In the past, referrals have been mainly from members of the Thai community, but this year there is an increase from other organisations.

Women's Monthly Meetings

Holding regular meetings with the women builds a stronger network. There were 12 information sessions held this year; six of them were in partnership with Hunter New England NSW Health and Migrant Health. Some of the topics covered were Women's Health, Legal Issues, Domestic Violence, the Use of Interpreters, Medication, etc.

After each session we enjoy a relaxed opportunity to socialise, where people with their children can attend – these sometimes coming as far as Singleton, Muswellbrook, Tea gardens and the Central Coast eat together and share friendships/networking. Attendance varies and can be between 10 to 30 people.

Religious Ceremonies

I have organised 3 cultural ceremonies for the community this year which were held at a local community hall. Buddhist monks from a temple in Sydney were invited to preside over the traditional ceremonies such as to make merit and to give alms. These events are popular and well supported in the community and the numbers of attendance have been growing with up to approximately 140 each session.

Other Activities

During the year, I have attended 6 trainings & workshops and 14 meetings with NSS, Interagency meetings, Centrelink Forums, and Domestic Violence Committees meetings in Newcastle and the Central Coast.

My work can be very challenging at times and to know I can call on the support and expertise of my colleagues at any time makes my work a lot easier. As with a lot of us, time is stretched and I'm finding it hard to keep up with the 14 hours per week boundary to assist all client demands.

Some highlights of the year:

INTERNATIONAL WOMEN'S DAY

Thai community participated in this event on the Central Coast; displayed Thai handicrafts and cooked Thai food for tasting at the Wyong Council Chambers. The table was a very popular one.

HARMONY DAY – Central Coast

I organised a display table for NSS along with a table displaying Thai weavings and handicrafts. Many enquiries were made regarding the work of the Thai Community & the Thai Welfare Project and 4 new clients were added from the Central Coast.

NEWCASTLE UNIVERSITY

I was invited to give a presentation on NSS services to 20 Thai professionals visiting from Thailand as well as discussing issues affecting the Thai Community in Newcastle and the Central Coast.

CULTURAL AWARENESS - Central Coast

Hosted a presentation to service providers on the use of interpreters



Strong Women, Stronger Communities Project (Domestic Violence Education & Support)

Nellie Srisurapon

Funded by Department of Community Services

The Strong Women, Stronger Communities Project was taken up by myself during May this year and ended in October. This project focused on empowering migrant and refugee women so to deal effectively with issues of family and domestic abuse. It also focused on women's rights & the services available and how to appropriately access them.

Another objective was to raise awareness among the service providers of gender related issues which disadvantaged those women.

During this period there were 13 information sessions organised for women from various communities. These communities included women from: Burundi, Sudan, Thailand, Russia, Equator and Mauritania.

The sessions had guest speakers and covered issues relating to Australian Law and applying for an AVO, Traffic Rules, contacting the Police, Using Interpreters, Domestic Violence and going to a refuge and Financial Planning. The sessions were mainly held at Penola House and each group would have between 5 to 15 participants.

Trips to the Family Court House and the Police Station were also arranged as follow up to the information sessions. These sessions were very useful to the women who seemed to enjoy them and ask many questions and with so much information and a lot of it being quite foreign I feel it would be worthwhile to repeat these sessions in the future. At each session information was provided on the particular topic presented, in the relevant language.

During this time I also assisted 18 women who had experienced DV. These women came from Cambodia, Burma, China, Korea, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Italy, Indonesia and Sudan. I also assisted one male humanitarian entrant from China.

A telephone interpreter was accessed to service some of these clients.

21 types of service were used to assist these clients with nearly all being referred on.



Above: The Cultural Awareness Workshop (for Service Providers) hosted by this project was a success.

Table 1: Issues and Instances of Service

ISSUE	Face To Face	Telephone	Group work / Sessions	Individuals attending
Immigration	5	7		
Education	1	2		
Housing	2	13		
Employment	1	9		
Income Support	2	6	2	13
Mental Health	1	4		
Domestic Violence	12	29	2	17
Legal	6	24	8	62
Refuge	3	7		
Police	2	16	1	8
Settlement	4	7		
Health		4		
Home visit/external assistance	8			
Court Support	4	6		
TOTAL	51	133		
Other Service Areas:	47 (Email, Fax, ordering resources and form assistance)			
TOTAL INSTANCES:	231			

Cultural Awareness Promotion

- Written information promoting cultural awareness was prepared & sent by hard mail and email.
- I visited 4 doctor's clinics to raise awareness on using interpreters and the process of registering for the Translating & Interpreting Service (TIS).
- I also organised a Cultural Awareness Workshop for Service Providers located throughout the Hunter (held at the NSS office, Newcastle).
The program for the 3 hour workshop included information about NSS as well as cross cultural training, using interpreters and accessing TIS, Immigration and the DV provision and accessing language resources. The program was jointly presented by fellow colleagues who did a fantastic job and left the participants wanting more. The workshop was attended by 39 participants and was received quite well. Each participant received a resource folder, useful for servicing CALD clients who have experienced DV. The session proved to be an excellent opportunity to network & promote a better understanding of NSS & its work. An Workshop Evaluation of the session provided feedback from the participants, which was quite positive & encouraging – most in support of more training and longer sessions. (photo previous page)

Meetings:

Newcastle DV Committee:2
DoCs Information Session:1
Staff meetings:4

I would like to thank the NSS Board & my colleagues for their support & also congratulate Violetta on another successful year of NSS management & operation.



Pacific Islander Welfare Project

Juanita Loli & Lydia Manusiu

Funded by Department of Community Services

The Pacific Islanders Welfare Project funded by Department of Community Services (DOCS) aims to assist Pacific Islanders with issues relating to:

- Accommodation
- Domestic Violence
- Employment
- Health
- Immigration (Citizenship Application & Sponsorship)
- Legal
- Youth etc.

The two workers aim to achieve objectives of:

1. Supporting children, young people, individual and families of Pacific Islanders to enable the enhancement of their independence, safety, self-esteem and or quality of life within the communities by:
 - i) providing information, advice, referrals and advocacy to individuals and families.
 - ii) providing group work to the Pacific Island Women's Groups attended by 10 – 20 women.
 - iii) providing tax assistance through Tax Help Volunteer Programs (ATO)
 - iv) providing ongoing support, advocacy and casework services to client group through case plan.
2. Building strong communities and social capital / undertaking community development so that Pacific Island Communities are well informed, resourced, and connected and that equity and diversity are embraced by:
 - i) providing information via the newsletters distributed monthly to the Samoans and bi-monthly to the Tongans. This information includes family activities in the areas the Pacific Islanders live and information regarding changes to government policies etc... The purpose being to inform Pacific Islanders to enhance awareness of relevant services they can access. Information is also transmitted on a weekly basis to the Samoan and Tongan Communities via the Community Radio programs on Radio 2NURFM 103.7 (Sunday nights for the Samoans & Friday nights for the Tongans) and is heard by an audience of 300 – 400.
 - ii) Workers maintain networking with government and non-government agencies and service providers by attending meetings throughout the year for awareness and development. Agencies and service providers include: Centrelink, Department of Housing, DOCS, Ethnic Communities Council, Hunter Tenants' Advice / Advocacy Service, Legal Aid, Migrant Health Services, Police Department Charlestown, etc...attending meetings ie Northern Settlement Services Caseworkers' Meetings, NSS Staff , Centrelink Multicultural Forum, CALD DOCS Advisory Group etc..

Other service provided is assessing the Northern Settlement Services' clients who need emergency relief or welfare assistance in paying bills ie Electricity, Gas, Telephone and Water.

ISSUES PRESENTED AND NUMBER OF CLIENTS

SERVICE OR ASSISTANCE PROVIDED	NUMBER OF CLIENTS
Accommodation & Housing Issues	69
Domestic Violence	10
Employment Issues	61
Health Issues	55
Immigration (Citizenship / Sponsorship)	243
Legal Issues	32
Youth Issues (Involving parenting issues)	26
Tax Returns (Tax Help Program)	252
EAPA (Welfare / Emergency Relief)	760

Clients who visit the Office to obtain assistance with Tax Returns and Welfare / Emergency Relief are not all of Pacific Island Background but are either Anglo Saxons with low income or Centrelink recipients as well as CALD. They are either self referred or referred by other service providers / or centre based referrals. Ongoing case management provided with support given via home visits and referral to other services.

A special message:

It has been a productive and busy year for us though interesting particularly with Lydia (Tongan Worker) getting married during the year and then moving to England for a new life, and myself taking leave of absence twice during the year to attend funerals of family members who passed on, the second occasion being for those who died as a result of the tsunami that devastated Samoa at the end of September 2009. I know it would have affected my work tremendously if I did not attend to my family but I took leave to go there. I wish to take this opportunity to thank the CEO for making this possible, and also for allowing the use of this centre as a collection point for the donations given by the charitable people of the Hunter.

I pray that you will always be blessed in abundance with everything you stand for -indeed NSS would not succeed without you. I have been so blessed to be working for such a wonderful and remarkable employer.

We wish to thank the Administration Staff for their dedication & for assisting staff with our needs in performing our duties accordingly and especially dealing with the donations that have come to the centre for the tsunami shipping containers.

You have all been brilliant in helping the Newcastle Samoan Community help the people of Samoa who have been affected by the tsunami. Friends & colleagues -I thank you all for everything.

May you all have a safe and happy holiday & festive season.



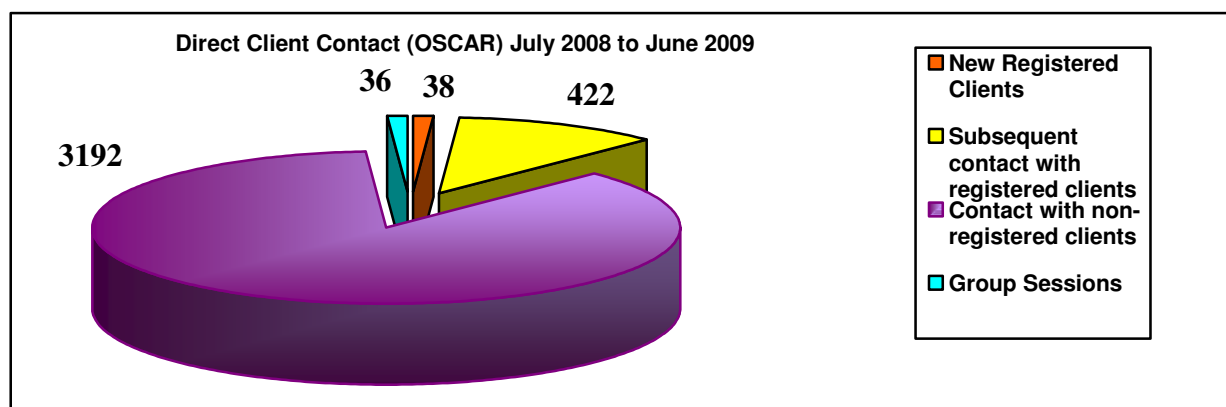
Migrant & Refugee Women's Support Project

Zenaída Edmunds

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
-under the Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

This is the last year of operation for this project which was a partnership between Northern Settlement Services and the Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre. This project provides support services to migrant and refugee women, who are experiencing physical and psychological crisis and hardships through isolation, effects of torture and trauma, domestic violence, homelessness and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement. This service includes; individual support, referrals, information sessions and group activities.

Table : Client Contact OSCAR



**Table 2:
Settlement Issues Presented**

Top 12 Issues	No. of Issues
Accommodation	87
Employment	63
Family and Relationships	62
Document Help	42
Education and Training	33
Childcare	32
Family Violence	26
Language	23
Social Participation	22
Health	20
Migration Advice (only by Migration Agent)	20
Parenting Practices	20

**Table 3:
Client's Ethnicity**

Top 11 Ethnicities	No. of Clients
Burundi	9
Sudanese	7
Korean	6
Liberian	6
Mandarin Chinese	5
Visayan	5
Thai	3
Cantonese	2
Filipino	2
Ilocano	2
Malaysian Chinese	2

Group Work: The project has established and facilitated the Burundi Women's Group and the Multicultural Women's Group. Group activities included orientation information sessions, which address life skills, accessing mainstream services and Australian social norms as well as sewing, cooking, music and dancing, participation in cultural events and visits to historical places in Newcastle and the Hunter.

Project's Outcomes for Clients:

Approximately 80% of clients assisted are now able to;

- Access mainstream support services independently.
- Has clear understanding of Australian legal and social norms especially domestic violence (DV) laws.
- Find accommodation, employment
- Manage their family finances
- Achieve harmony in family relationships.

The reasons others were not able to achieve full benefits of the project because of limited English which limits their independence, limited participation in attending information sessions because of unavailability of transport and suitable child care.

Issues still need to address:

Harmony in Family Relationships: There are still a small number of families in the target group with teen-age children that are experiencing difficulties in finding the right balance in living harmoniously within the family in Australian setting. Intensive and individualized support is needed for these families.

Financial management: There are still families in the target group experiencing difficulties in managing their financial situation which causes family friction and disharmony. Successful financial management and budgeting will take much longer time especially women from the target group, whose personal experience did, not involve money management. It will take intensive support and regular follow-up to support these families.

Highlights of the Project:

- The establishment of the Burundi Women's choir as a community based organisation managed by a management committee. They have elected a president, vice-president, treasurer and secretary. The choir group is now performing in a professional manner and receiving donations to purchase materials for their costume. They are now establishing a children's choir, the aim is to teach their children their own songs and dances.
- The inclusion of one of the Sudanese women in a photographic exhibition, called "Women in the Hunter", to celebrate the International Women's Day. This was organised by Newcastle City Council; the photographs were exhibited at Wallsend District Library for the month of April, 2009. She was also featured in the local weekend magazine.
- There are now 5 women from Multicultural Women's Group that are employed as Bicultural Support Pool Workers, working in various childcare centre and pre-schools.
- A large number of women from the target group are now accessing children's services.

I would like to thank my colleagues especially my team leader, Pet Kelly for ongoing support and encouragement, Alex Burns for work program guidance and direction and Amany George, MNC Manager for ongoing technical support.



Multicultural Family Support Project (Families First)

Miza Torlakovic

Funded by the Department of Community Services

NSW Department of Community Services funds multicultural Family Project under the NSW- *Families First* program. This project provides support to new parents and families with children aged 0-8, from culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) backgrounds. The target group comprises first time parents, teenage parents and to parents with a developmental disability; and/or other special needs, living in the Newcastle and Lake Macquarie LGAs.

During the 12 month period a total of 61 families coming from 25 different ethnic backgrounds have accessed the service. The families have mainly come from referrals by Hunter Area Health, Women's refuges, Child Care Services, Child and Family Health, Mental Health Services, Housing services, TAFE and Schools. Referrals also come through community services, other early intervention services as well as through NSS and self referrals.

Table 1 indicates the issues were presented. As can be seen the 61 clients had face to face and telephone during this year.

Table 1: Number of Client Contact Instances and Issues

Problems/ Issues	Face to Face	Telephone	Problems/ Issues	Face to Face	Telephone
Immigration & Citizenship	41	54	Childcare	71	107
Income Support & Finances	176	266	Youth Issues	40	52
Employment	17	33	Domestic Violence	67	115
Education & Training	31	53	Family problem	171	164
Overseas Qualifications	8	18	Legal	83	131
Learning English	51	53	Police	6	16
Accommodation & Housing	132	153	Settlement Information	49	72
Health	78	104	Mental Health	80	159
Torture & Trauma	29	35	Other	116	181
Total	563	769		683	997

***Other** occasions of service includes: Isolation, home/hospitals visits, case conferences, assisting with documents, transport and filling forms.

The service has operated with flexibility, with 33 of the assisted families being regularly provided with out of hours support, on weekends and public holidays. i.e. services were provided as families needed them.

Home visits were used as a good opportunity to observe parent/child interaction, engagement and behaviour, and to provide informal education sessions as needed. Where required, home visitations were conducted with other service providers, and one on one education in the home covered i.e. risk assessment and management, hygienic practices in the home, dietary needs, parenting skills in general and other general support

Informal cultural awareness training /project presentation has been provided to mainstream and community services to which referrals have been made. These sessions are as follows: to the Preparation Group for Home Start (13 volunteers), 6 TAFE counsellors, 2 different sessions for Westlake Family In Sight – (10 volunteers), 30 TAFE Certificate 4 Community Services Students, Children's Services, CALD Arts and Services Forum - 30 service providers.

TIS Interpreters and NSS Bi-lingual workers used in Arabic, Dinka, Spanish, Mandarin, Kirundi, helped facilitate the work of the service.

The Families First project strongly networks with a wide range of mainstream and community agencies to deliver the service and these included: the Hunter New England Multicultural Service, the John Hunter Hospital, Community Mental Health Services in Newcastle and Lake Macquarie, the Department of Housing, Compass Housing, all women's Refuges, Women's Housing, the Family In Sight project, Newcastle Home Start-Family Action Centre, Newcastle Family Support, Hunter Community Legal Centre, Hunter Women's Domestic Violence Court Advocacy Service, Early Childhood Intervention Program -Special Education Centre(University of Newcastle), TAFE and various Child Care/ Play Schools, Churches and other Charity organizations.

Project Highlights

Three high need clients with multiple complex circumstances were successfully referred to the DIAC Complex Case Support Scheme for ongoing support and coordination of service inputs.

Training and Skill Building

The project has had good training opportunities which have included: Triple P training in Maitland in June, 2009. While the training was a good reminder of the important aspects of parenting for our own practices, it was inappropriate for use with the vast majority of clients with whom the service comes in contact. Access to this program requires a level of education and capacity by clients, which is clearly not the case with our CALD client base. Accordingly, we did not proceed to accreditation level with Triple P. Grant and Project Management Workshop – Hunter Area Consultative Committee, Working with Diversity- DOCS, Community Agency Information Forum – Housing Appeal Committee, Triple P Information session, Community Mental Health Strategy – Mental Health and Drug & Alcohol, Power Point Presentation at CALD Arts and Services Forum – Hunter Culture, One Day Suicide Prevention Workshop – Life Force, Lower Hunter Community Forum on Health.

I would like to thank Violetta for her support of this project, my work & for her dedication (& longevity!) to the purpose of this agency.

FINANCE & ADMINISTRATION TEAM



Ms Arlene Richards
Financial Controller



Ms Marianne Mohr
Assistant Financial Controller



Mary Milevski
Office Manager



Silvia Ruano - McLerie
Senior Administration Officer



Ms Helen Short
Administration Officer



Olivia Graham
Administration Officer
(on-call)



Wendy Kirkham
Administration Officer
(on-call)



Jacinta Boidin
Administration Trainee



Lydia Manusiu
Administration Officer
(on-call) -Resigned October 09



Ms Helen Buchanan
OH&S Consultant

CENTRE USAGE

2008 - 2009

African Community Council (Hunter)	Latvian Group
Audit & Finance Committee (NSS)	Lettesi
Ba'hai Community of Newcastle	United 'Boyce' Dance Troupe
Bosnian Community of Newcastle	Migrant Health Unit
Burundi Dance Group	Multicultural Dementia Carers Group
Burundi Women's Choir	Newcastle & Hunter Ethnic Choral Society
Burundi Community of Newcastle	Newcastle Theatre Company
Burundi & Congolese Community	Newcastle Multicultural Interagency
Centrelink Multicultural Forum	Newcastle Akebono Japanese Group
Community Refugee Support	New Arrival Welcomes
DIAC Immigration Officers Outreach	Pacific RAC
Estonian Community of Newcastle	PCG Church
Filipino Community Choir	Russian Women's Group
Filipino Women's Group	Russian School
First Aid Group	Refugee Council
French Group	Samoan Women's Group
Greek Macedonian Brotherhood Pavlos Melas	Slovenian Association of Newcastle "Tivoli"
Hamilton Multicultural Walkers	Spanish Group
Hamilton Olympic Soccer Club	STARTTS Counselling
Hunter Refugee Network	Sudanese Community of Newcastle
Hunter Community Legal Clinic	Tamil Language School
Migrant Interagency	Tongan Choir
International Singers	United Nations Association Australia





'Happy Retirement' Irina Lupish



After 21 years of service with
Northern Settlement Services,
our friend & colleague
Irina Lupish
announced her retirement.
The Board & staff gathered
to wish her a fond farewell.

(Bimet Lodge 1/10/2008)

NSS Staff Day hosted by NSS Central Coast





(Above left) NSS Chairman Henry Chan with Central Coast Team Leader Sandra Wingrave & Mayor of Wyoma Bob Graham



(Above Right) NSS Treasurer Trudy Mills-Evers pictured with guests at the opening



Grand Opening Northern Settlement Services Central Coast



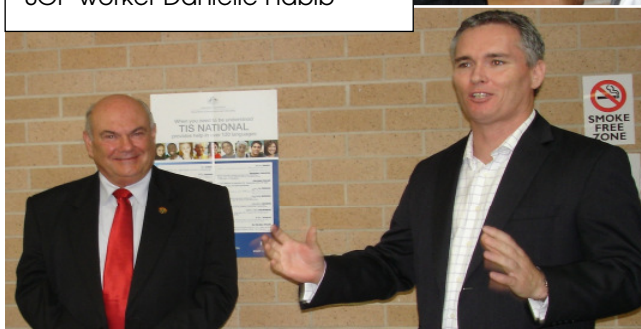
(Above) NSS Chairman Henry Chan with NSS CEO Violetta Walsh & NSS Board Directors Father Zervas & Anna Marendy (at right)



(Above left) NSS Chairman Henry Chan with Central Coast SGP worker Danielle Habib



(Above) NSS Deputy CEO Lulu Tantos with Phocian Vouros (Greek Hellenic Society)



(Above) Mayor of Wyong Mr Bob Graham & Federal Member Craig Thomson MP (Dobell)



(Above) NSS Rural Team Leader with NSS Board Director Father Zervas

Refugee Week 2009

Activities hosted by Northern Settlement Services,
Ethnic Communities Council, Centrelink, ACL,
Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre & STARTTS





FINANCIAL REPORT

as provided by

**Cutcher & Neale
Chartered Accountants**

For the year ending 30 June 2009